

PICK IT UP E LLC · GRAND FORKS, ND · EAST GRAND FORKS, MN

The Business Plan

Fall 2026 → Spring 2027 · rank first, fill the truck, keep the cash

Price before you call. Book in 60 seconds.

Leaves gone before the city vacuum.

This is the working document for one truck, one owner and up to two helpers. It says what to do this week, what to do every Monday, what a job is worth, how many jobs make what profit, and what not to do. Every external number carries its source in Appendix B; every internal number comes from the pricebook or the books, never from feel. Numbers marked $n=0$ are estimates that the first season's data will replace — the crew clock, the $\$$ = source tags and the Google review count are the three that matter most.

5 jobs

A MONTH COVERS THE NUT

20 reviews

BY NOV 12 WINS THE LEAF PACK

Oct 6 – Nov 8

THE LEAF SEASON, BY THE WEATHER

Prepared 13 September 2026 from live research (competitors, local search, Census, city code, MN/ND tax, industry economics) verified against primary sources, plus the repository's pricebook and books. Owner copy — contains cost and compliance detail; the crew portal shows none of it.

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1

The plan on one page

The bet. In Greater Grand Forks nobody local ranks a real leaf-cleanup page, nobody publishes a leaf or gutter price, no junk hauler offers a live estimate or online booking, and East Grand Forks has no real local result for junk or leaves at all. The site already automates estimate → booking → \$50 deposit → confirmation → owner board → crew portal → mileage → receipts. So the next 60 days go to the two things that move a Google local pack — a completely built Google Business Profile (≈25–32% of pack weight) and steady review velocity (≈20%) — plus five unique service pages, while the truck works Saturdays and two evenings a week around the W-2 job.

The position. Three services, one truck, flat prices shown before the call, booked in a minute with a \$50 deposit that comes off the bill. Leaves priced by the lot; junk by the truck bed; single-story gutters from the ground with no ladder on the siding. The Fargo franchises drive 75 miles; we are on Belmont Road.

Ranking verdict for day 60 (Nov 12). #1 organic and top-3 pack for *leaf cleanup / leaf removal Grand Forks* (the pack is mowing companies with 54–89 reviews and no leaf page); #1 organic for every *East Grand Forks* term; #1–2 organic for *yard debris removal Grand Forks*; #2–3 in the junk pack behind Haul Away Junk & Demo (≈110 reviews, not beatable on reviews in 60 days); pack entry only for gutters (incumbents at 121 and 76). Brand term "Pick It Up E" owns page 1 by Sept 27.

The money, in one line

A job keeps about **\$246 ticket · \$34 variable cost · \$213 kept per job · 3.23 h per job including drive and dump** (solo, blended fall mix). The fixed nut the business must clear is **\$1,013 a month**, so **5 jobs a month** covers it and everything past that is profit before tax. Four jobs a Saturday for nine Saturdays (36 jobs) clears about **\$3,900 after tax**; six a week (54 jobs) about **\$6,600**. The full ladder is in §8.

Five things block hauling legally, and they happen this week (\$2, \$9)

1. **Bind the general-liability policy** (NEXT quote ≈\$85/mo) — the hauler permit, landlord COIs and Local Services Ads all need it.
2. **File the Grand Forks private-hauler permit** (City Code §13-0406.1, \$75, council approval, bond + proof of liability). "Rubbish" in that code includes lawn clippings and discarded furniture — leaf hauls and junk hauls both need it. Until it issues: sell rake-to-the-curb leaf jobs (no hauling on city streets) and haul only outside city limits.
3. **Get a written yes/no from GF Finance** (701-746-2664) on whether hanging a door hanger without knocking is "door-to-door sales" under Ordinance 4707 — before the hangers go out.
4. **Call Progressive and disclose business use** — a personal auto policy typically excludes hauling for pay; a claim during a paid haul is deniable today.
5. **EIN the day the LLC shows active** (~Sept 18), then the Minnesota Tax ID before any East Grand Forks job — Minnesota taxes all three services (8.375% sales tax on leaf and gutter work, 9.75% solid-waste tax on junk hauls); North Dakota taxes none of them.

The 3-a-day target. Worked in full in the next section: it is a two-week peak around Oct 12–24, not an eight-week average — ≈70–95 jobs for the season with leave from Oct 5, ≈40–55 with the W-2 job kept, versus 144 as stated. What breaks first is the permit calendar, then your weekday hours, then the hanger ruling.

Weekly rhythm. Monday, 60 minutes at the desk (reviews, GBP post, staggered review asks, block-deal texts, scorecard). Thursday, 45 minutes (Facebook groups on their promo day, two property-manager calls, Saturday routing by street). Saturday on the truck, clustered by street, 20–30 hangers on every block worked. Ads only Oct 1–Nov 15, only on leaf terms, \$15 a day, with a kill rule.

2

This week — Sept 14–20, in dependency order

What blocks what: GL insurance → hauler permit → Local Services Ads. LLC active → EIN → Minnesota Tax ID, WSI, Twilio toll-free verification, bank account. Nothing below needs a second person.

Monday — legal and money (2 h)

- ☐ Bind NEXT general liability, \$1M/\$2M. Download the certificate of insurance.
- ☐ Call GF Finance 701-746-2620 / GFlicensing@grandforksgov.com: request the **Private Collector of Rubbish, Construction Refuse and White Goods** permit application; ask the bond amount and the next City Council agenda date. Write both on the \$9 table.
- ☐ Email slundmark@grandforksgov.com (Finance, 701-746-2664): "Is leaving a printed door hanger on a doorknob, without knocking or speaking, 'door-to-door sales' under Ordinance 4707?" Keep the reply in print/DOOR-HANGER.md.
- ☐ Call Public Works 701-738-8740: does a commercial pickup dumping loose leaves at 724 N 47th St pay anything? (It is the one unverified per-job cost.) Submit the Landfill Waste Profile Form.
- ☐ Call Progressive: disclose business use, get the commercial-auto (or business-use) quote. Add hired & non-owned auto if a helper will ever drive.

Tuesday — the ranking foundation (2 h)

- ☐ Google Business Profile, complete (\$5 Day 0–7 list): 4 categories, 6 priced services, hours Mon–Sat 7–8, 20 photos, 8 Q&A, first post, messaging on, website link pickitup.com/?s=gbp.
- ☐ Copy the GBP "Get more reviews" link and fix REVIEW_URL — today every review ask lands on a Maps *search* page, not the write-a-review box. Highest-leverage 20 minutes in this plan.
- ☐ Citations with identical name / phone / city / URL: Bing Places (import from GBP), Apple Business Connect, Yelp, Nextdoor business page, Facebook page, BBB free profile.

Wednesday — the site (2 h)

- ☐ Home H1 with the service and the city; "East Grand Forks" and the neighborhoods in body text; unique titles on /book and /call; canonical on every route; footer NAP block matching GBP character-for-character; JSON-LD with geo, hours, service area, sameAs.
- ☐ Request indexing in Search Console for /, /book, /call, /plan, /landlords, /about (only the home page is indexed today).
- ☐ Decide the promo: hangers now go out after Sept 20, so extend PROMO_DEADLINE to Oct 10 or the printed "lock by Sept 20" reads as expired the day it's hung.

Thursday — people (45 min)

- ☐ Join the five Facebook groups (\$6); read each group's promo-day rule.
- ☐ Two property-manager calls from the \$6 list; ask who handles December turnovers.
- ☐ EIN at irs.gov the moment the SOS shows the LLC active (10 minutes, free). Then Twilio Business Profile → toll-free number → verification (PHONE-LINE.md).

Friday / Saturday — the street

- ☐ Hangers arrive Sept 17. Hang only after Finance answers; 9am–8pm; knob only, never the mailbox (18 U.S.C. §1725); skip every house with a no-soliciting or no-trespassing sign.
- ☐ First jobs: rake-to-curb leaf work and jobs outside city limits until the permit issues; take deposits for October dates inside the city.
- ☐ Photos of the truck and every job for GBP (no faces without permission).

The load-bearing assumption nobody has written down

Every capacity number in this plan assumes the truck runs **Saturdays plus two weekday evenings** around the W-2 job — about 18–20 truck hours a week, 6–7 jobs solo, 8–10 with a helper on leaf days. If PTO can cover the two city-vacuum weeks (tentatively Oct 19–30), the base case rises from ~36 to ~55 jobs. Decide the PTO by Oct 1 and write it on the calendar in §13.

THE TARGET

Three jobs a day, six days a week, until snowfall

The owner's stated target is 18 completed jobs a week from now until the snow. Four builders (leads, staffing, the day, the market) and one skeptic worked it against the ground truth. The verdict, unvarnished:

Verdict

18 a week is a two-week peak (about Oct 12–24), not an eight-week average. It is reachable in those weeks only if the hauler permit is in hand, the helper is legally on the truck by Oct 5, the owner is on the truck Mon–Sat from Oct 5, hangers scale to ~1,500 doors a week with a written city ruling, and the weather is a median-or-better year. The realistic season is **≈70–95 completed jobs with leave from Oct 5** and **≈40–55 with the W-2 job kept**, against 144 as stated. The good news: the plan degrades gracefully — every case clears the winter escrow.

Case	Jobs by week (from Mon Sept 14)	Jobs	Revenue	Pre-tax	After tax	Your hours	Helper hours	After-tax \$/h
Target as stated: 3 a day, 6 days, from week 1	18 · 18 · 18 · 18 · 18 · 18 · 18 · 18 · 18 · 9	153	\$37,672	\$25,156	\$17,609	378.36	262.08	\$47
Realistic — owner full-time from Oct 5, helper from Sept 28	2 · 4 · 6 · 11 · 15 · 17 · 14 · 10 · 5	84	\$20,682	\$12,240	\$8,568	194.1	174.72	\$44
Realistic — W-2 job kept (Saturdays, Sundays, two evenings)	2 · 4 · 5 · 7 · 8 · 8 · 7 · 5 · 3	49	\$12,065	\$8,319	\$5,823	158.27	0	\$37

Same job economics as §8 (helper from the third week in the first two cases). The stated-target row assumes 18 a week from day one, which nothing below permits; it is there to show what the number would be worth.

Week by week — what binds, and what unlocks the next step

Week	Target	Realistic (leave from Oct 5)	W-2 kept	What binds that week
Sept 14	18	2	2	No hauler permit → in-city work is gutters only; leaves not down; no written hanger ruling; W-2 hours
Sept 21	18	4	4	Owner hours (21 available vs 32 needed); 2,500 hangers land ~Sept 22 and go out only with the ruling
Sept 28	18	6	5	Still no in-city hauls; canopy holds; helper's first shift Sept 28 at the earliest (WSI)
Oct 5	18	11	7	Booking lag — this week's jobs come from W2–W3 leads; permit effective Oct 6 if on the Oct 5 agenda; first 28°F drops the leaves
Oct 12	18	15	8	First arithmetically possible 18-week; Saturday tips only 2 loads; 25th-percentile first snow is this week
Oct 19	18	17	8	Route weeks → rake-to-curb at the bottom of the band (4–5 houses/day, ticket ~20%); median first snow next week
Oct 26	18	14	7	Median first measurable snow; DST ends Nov 1 (sunset 5:09); a dusting = 2 leaf jobs max that day
Nov 2	18	10	5	Sunset 5:09 + landfill 4:00 → no solo unchained 3-job day; median 1-inch snow Nov 8
Nov 9	9	5	3	Snow; gutters stop when debris freezes; junk only

After Oct 19 the in-city product is rake-to-the-curb at the bottom of each leaf band (\$160 / \$240 / \$335): 4–5 houses a day are possible, but the blended ticket falls to about \$200–215, so 90 jobs is nearer \$19–20k of revenue than \$22k. Revenue in the tables above uses the §8 mix; treat it as the ceiling.

What breaks first — in order

- The permit calendar, not demand.** City Council meets the 1st and 3rd Monday at 5:30 pm — Sept 21, Oct 5, Oct 19. Until §13-0406.1 issues, every in-city haul (leaf and junk) is off; in-city work is gutters and, from Oct 19, rake-to-curb. Leaves aren't down before the ~Oct 6 first 28°F anyway. Get the agenda-submission deadline from the City Clerk Monday and make the Oct 5 agenda; miss it and the permit lands Oct 20.
- Your weekday hours.** 18 jobs is 58 owner-hours a week solo, 40 with a helper on every job — plus the Monday desk hour and 12–15 hours a week of hanging that someone has to do. Weekends plus two evenings is ~21 hours → 6–8 jobs a week. Nothing bridges Sept 21–Oct 11 except leave you haven't requested. Rule: **decide on Oct 3 — if 25+ deposit-paid bookings sit on the board, take leave from Oct 5; if not, run the weekend plan.** Check the W-2 handbook's outside-employment clause first.
- The literature-drop ruling.** ~70% of modeled leads are hangers. No written ruling under Ordinance 4707 = 0 in-city hangers; each week of slip removes 15–22 leads.

4. **The helper's week is 52–56 hours, not 40**, if the same person hangs. Overtime at 1.5× or a second part-time hanger: loaded wages are ≈\$1,100 a week, not \$806.
5. **Booking-to-completion lag.** September leads are October dates; the first arithmetically possible 18-week is Oct 12–17, and the 25th-percentile first snow is that same week.
6. **Saturday's dump window.** Landfill 8–11; the yard-waste site appears closed Saturday (unconfirmed — 701-738-8740). Saturday = two hauls tipped by 11 plus one no-haul job (gutter or rake-to-curb).
7. **Lead volume itself.** Google is capped by search volume — roughly 120 junk-removal searches a month in this metro — at 5–9 leads a week no matter the budget; hangers and the block-deal loop are the volume.
8. **Weather.** Median first measurable snow Oct 26; median 1-inch Nov 8. After Nov 1 the sun sets at 5:09 and the landfill still closes at 4:00, so a solo unchained 3-job day no longer fits.
9. **Cash before Oct 3.** ≈\$3.5–4k goes out (print \$903, ads ~\$440, Nextdoor \$140, GL, permit + bond, WSI \$250 minimum, first payroll ~\$813 on Oct 2) against maybe \$2–3k collected. Not fatal with W-2 income; it means the 5,000-hanger run waits for the calibration read.

The volume machine — what it costs

Move	When	Cost	Yield (n=0)
Reorder 2,500 hangers (VistaPrint 4.5×11, same art) + priority ship	Mon Sept 14 → lands ~Sept 22	\$299 + ~\$45	1,500 doors/wk at 1–1.5% → 15–22 leads/wk, arriving over 2–4 weeks
Order 5,000 more — only if the first 1,500 doors produce ≥15 ? s=dh leads in 14 days	Sept 21 → lands ~Sept 29	\$499 + ship	W3–W7 volume
Hanging labor: 120 doors/hour on the old grid → 1,500 doors = 12.5 h/wk	From W2	\$0.17/door if a helper hangs	Owner in W1 (3 evenings 5:30–7:15); a second part-timer from W3
Google Ads, leaf/yard-waste terms only	Oct 1–Nov 15	\$15–30/day (the market can't absorb more)	5–9 leads/wk ceiling
Nextdoor boost, four hanger zones	Oct 1–21	\$210	2–3/wk
Facebook groups, daily replies within the hour	Now	\$0	3–6/wk — the largest unverified channel
Block-deal loop: 25 hangers on every worked block	Every job	\$3/job	0.15–0.34 extra jobs per completed job
Local Services Ads	Apply the day GL binds	\$60/wk	2–3/wk once screened (3–4 weeks)

Where to hang, in order: the city's route-1 zone (east of S Washington, DeMers to 32nd Ave S — oldest canopy, vacuumed first) → Riverside / Near North → Lincoln Drive Park / Near Southside → Belmont / Reeves / Chestnut south to 17th → south of 32nd (junk-forward message) → East Grand Forks only after the MN Tax ID. Skip the UND rental belt.

The crew — fastest legal path

- **Now:** post the job (UND job board, Job Service ND, the Facebook groups, Indeed): seasonal outdoor helper, \$18–20/h, Mon–Sat availability, start "on or after Sept 28 pending workers' comp". Interview by phone; keep a bench of two — seasonal no-shows run about one in three.
- **Day the LLC is active (~Sept 18):** EIN online (instant, weekdays 7am–10pm ET) → WSI Application for Insurance the same day (coverage effective on approval; no SLA published — call 800-777-5033 to expedite; \$250 minimum premium, offset by the new-business credit) → ND withholding account → open Square Payroll (\$35 + \$6/person/mo) or Gusto.
- **First shift:** the day WSI approves, Sept 26–28 at the earliest. W-4 and I-9 Section 1 in the payroll app before; I-9 Section 2 within three business days.
- **First pay date Oct 2, not earlier** — keeps every first filing in Q4. Job Service ND registration by Oct 16 (within 20 days of first hire).
- **Configuration:** one helper on every job (owner 6.7 h/day, helper 6.7 h/day, ≈\$813/wk loaded at 40 h). A second helper only pays at 4+ jobs a day — drive and dump time don't shrink with headcount. Cap the truck helper at 40 h; hanging is a second part-timer or the owner.

The three day templates

- **A — Leaf block day (Tue/Thu/Sat):** 7:15 load → one drive leg → house 1 (8:00–10:10) → dump → house 2 → lunch in the cab → house 3 → dump 2 (landfill leg before 4:00 if any junk rode along) → 20–30 hangers on the block → home 4:20. Solo ≈9.0 h; with a helper ≈6.5 h. **Route-week variant:** no dump runs, berm the leaves 3 ft from the curb → 4 houses.
- **B — Mixed day (Mon/Wed):** gutter 8:00 → junk 9:40 → landfill 11:00 → leaf 12:10 → yard-waste tip → hangers → home 3:25. Any lot over 10,000 sf is job 1, never job 3.
- **C — Junk + gutter day (Fri):** junk 8:00 → landfill → gutter 10:30 → junk 12:30 → landfill by 2:30 → record pay, receipts, mileage → 60–100 hangers on next week's route-week streets.
- **Rules:** a haul block day is capped at two dump runs (tread the load down; mow-in the last 20% with permission); frost mornings start on the sunny side after ~Oct 6; wet leaves = 1.6× hours = two houses, not three; any ≥2-inch snow forecast triggers the 48-hour push and hangers off.

The eight conditions — each one testable on the board

1. §13-0406.1 application on the published Oct 5 council agenda and approved that night.
2. Written Ordinance 4707 ruling in hand by Sept 21, before the 2,500 hangers land.
3. ≥25 deposit-paid bookings on /jobs by Oct 3 → leave from Oct 5 through Nov 7.
4. Helper's first punch on /crew by Oct 5, capped at 40 h; wages accepted at ≈\$1,100/wk loaded.
5. First 1,500 doors → ≥15 ?s=dh leads within 14 days (1.0%); under 10 → downside plan, no 5,000 run.
6. ≥40% of leads become deposit-paid bookings ($n \geq 20$ by Oct 3); at 30% the requirement becomes 60 leads a week and nothing delivers it.
7. ≥50% of leaf jobs on same-street pairs or triples by the week of Oct 12; yard-waste gate hours confirmed.
8. A median-or-better snow year: nothing lasting before Nov 8, no measurable snow before Oct 19.

Fallbacks

- **Permit misses Oct 5:** rake-to-curb inside the city from Oct 19 at the bottom of the band (4–5 houses/day, no dump); hauls only outside city limits and in EGF after the MN Tax ID; re-book in-city haul customers as route-week curb-pile jobs.
- **No written ruling by Sept 21:** hand-to-hand only (worked blocks, handoffs), rural routes, Facebook replies on a 30-minute clock, Nextdoor posts; hold the 5,000 print.
- **No leave from the W-2 job:** weekends only — Saturday two hauls tipped by 11 plus one no-haul, Sunday rake-to-curb and gutters (everything closed, no dump); 6–8 jobs a week; helper ~14 h/wk; cut marketing to 500 hangers a week and no Google so the calendar doesn't fill with dates the truck can't serve.
- **WSI slips past Oct 3:** solo, two jobs a day on unchained days, three only on block days; keep the bench warm.
- **Early snow:** 48-hour push, then text every unfinished leaf booking the day it sticks — deposit rolls to a spring cleanup at the locked promo rate or refunds; flip to junk and gutters; helper weekends only.

3

Market & competitors

Who holds each Google result today

Review counts are from Sept 13 search snippets and third-party profiles; Google Maps itself could not be read from this session — log the real 3-pack every Friday from a phone in Grand Forks (\$10).

Search	Who ranks	What they have	What they lack	Reviews
junk removal Grand Forks	Haul Away Junk & Demo (2023, BBB A+)	Six service pages, organic #1–3, Angi 5.0	No prices, no online booking, no yard/leaf service	≈110 Google
junk removal Grand Forks	Junk Bros (phone-only), Forks Clearview (2025)	Junk Bros also lists yard work and gutter clearing	No website, no prices, phone booking	unknown
junk removal Grand Forks	Get’ErDone Moving	The only published local rate: junk \$125/hour; Thumbtack 4.7 (93)	Sells time, not a flat quote	93 Thumbtack
junk (organic)	LoadUp, Grunber, HitJunk, 1-800-GOT-JUNK	National doorway pages; LoadUp publishes pickup from \$85, yard debris from \$115	No local crew; 1-800-GOT-JUNK and College Hunks dispatch from Fargo, 75 miles	national
leaf removal / fall cleanup Grand Forks	Meticulous Mowing, PRO Land Snow, Lost Limb Logging, Lawn King, Reco, Custom Works	Mowing and tree companies; fall cleanup is a sideline	No leaf page, no per-lot price, no online booking; "estimate within a week"	54–89 Google (top 4)
leaf (organic)	City of Grand Forks, Angi, lead-gen doorways	The free city vacuum page	No local specialist page ranks — the most winnable term	—
leaves + junk + gutters together	Rachel's Property Solutions	Online booking, "from \$30"	Pet-waste business first; no estimate widget, no job prices	unknown
gutter cleaning Grand Forks	First Class Exterior Cleaning, Absolute Glass (Jobber booking, Google Guaranteed)	Window-cleaning firms	No published price; nobody sells "single-story, from the ground"	121 / 76
anything + East Grand Forks	nobody local	855/833 numbers and doorway pages	Open lane	—

The open lane: nobody in the market combines leaves + junk + gutters with a published price, a live estimate, online booking and a deposit. That is the position; the pack and the five pages are how the market finds it.

Demand you are selling into

11,169

OWNER-OCCUPIED DETACHED HOUSES (GF + EGF)

4,431

OWNER HOUSEHOLDERS 65+ — THE FIRST SEGMENT

1,195

RENTER-OCCUPIED HOUSES — THE LANDLORD SEGMENT

29,616 occupied households across both cities (ACS 2024 5-year). Estimated paid leaf cleanups per fall ≈1,400–2,100 (n=0 — inferred from a 36% any-pro yard-service hire rate); paid junk hauls ≈1,500 a year; single-story gutter jobs ≈750–1,100 a year. Fifty leaf jobs is 2–4% of the market. The door hangers aim at the ~3,400 owner-occupied single-family 65+ households: the one segment where the hire rate is high enough to make a 500-card drop pay, and the same people who cannot lift a couch or climb for gutters.

The clock

Date	What happens	What it means for the calendar
Sept 17–20	Hangers arrive; promo deadline (extend to Oct 10)	Pre-book with deposits; sell "before the city vacuum"
~Sept 28 / Oct 6	First 32°F / first 28°F (NWS normals)	Leaves drop; leaf season opens
Oct 5–9	East Grand Forks Fall Cleanup — free curbside bulky pickup	Sell EGF junk as "what the city won't take"; junk demand pulls to the week before and two weeks after
Week of Oct 19 (tentative)	Grand Forks street leaf-vacuum starts (Oct 17 / 23 / 21 / 20 in 2022–25), routes run to mid-Nov, loose leaves within 3 ft of the curb, no bags	The demand engine, not a competitor: the paid job is raked to the curb before the street's pass. Schedule by route week
Oct 26 / Nov 8	Median first measurable snow / median first 1-inch snow	Plan leaf work to end Nov 8; Nov 9–20 overflow only, weather-permitting

Date	What happens	What it means for the calendar
Nov 16–30	47% of days already have 1"+ snow cover	Junk and gutters only; winter escrow must be funded
Mid-Dec / late May	UND semester turnovers	Landlord packs
Apr 16 – May 15	Spring window (last 32°F ≈ May 14); GF Spring Cleanup ~May 11–15, EGF ~May 18–22	Two-visit plan customers first; junk pulls into the two weeks before each cleanup week

4

Positioning & offer

One line, everywhere (hero, GBP description, every page intro, the phone greeting): *Price before you call. Book in 60 seconds. Leaves gone before the city vacuum.*

Service	Pricebook (src/lib/pricebook.ts — the only place prices live)	How to sell it
Fall leaf & yard cleanup	\$32–46 per 1,000 sq ft on city lots → 5,000 sf \$160–230 · 7,500 sf \$240–345 · 12,000 sf corner \$335–490 · half acre \$530–780 · acre \$840–1,260	"Raked, tarped and hauled — or piled at the curb the week before your street's vacuum pass." The city takes loose leaves only, no bags, within 3 ft of the curb.
Junk, furniture, appliances	Bags or one piece \$59–95 · a few pieces \$85–130 · half bed \$125–195 · full bed \$175–265 · two trips \$245–365 · cleanout add-on +\$50–100. Refuses paint, chemicals, oil, propane, concrete, dirt, roofing, asbestos	"Flat price by the truck bed, not by the hour." Quote under Get'ErDone's \$125/hour and beside LoadUp's \$85 + \$15 per item.
Single-story gutters	\$135–165 standard · \$175–215 wraparound; as a leaf add-on \$80–110 / \$110–145	"From the ground with a 120V vacuum — no ladders on your siding. Two-story? We'll tell you straight and hand you off." The honesty the window firms can't copy.
Two-visit plan (spring re-book)	Small \$225 → \$180/yr · standard \$350 → \$280 · large \$575 → \$460 (20% off the pair, cap \$150, Stripe prepay, no deposit, never stacks)	The spring vehicle in every done text after Nov 1 — /plan, not an invented "\$50 holds April".
Landlord packs	Multi-stop turnovers; deposit \$75 at 2 stops, \$100 at 3+, combo up to \$150; net-15 invoicing	Property managers and the 1,195 rented houses; December and late May.

Deals already in the pricebook — they are the referral program, don't invent another

- **Promo:** book by Sept 20 (extend to Oct 10) for 20% off up to \$75. Locks the rate, not the date. Change only PROMO_DEADLINE / PROMO_DEADLINE_LABEL.
- **Block deal:** two houses on one street the same day \$25 off each, three or more \$40 off each. Never stacks with the promo — the customer gets the bigger one. This is the neighbor engine: every booked address gets 20–30 hangers on its block.
- **\$50 deposit** on every booking, credited to the invoice — and the cash-timing weapon: a September pre-book puts \$50 in the account six weeks before the leaves fall.

The one pricing decision to make now

During Grand Forks route weeks (about Oct 19 – Nov 13) quote the **low end** of the leaf range for rake-to-the-curb jobs and the **high end** for full tarp-and-haul. Both are inside the published range, so no price is invented — and it makes the curb-pile job, the one with no dump run and the best cash per hour (\$8), the default inside city limits. Also: the single-item junk job (\$59–95) barely covers its own dump run and drive — take it only chained to another stop on the same street, and chain two half-beds onto one landfill run (\$23 minimum either way).

How to say it, by surface

- **Against the Fargo franchises:** "1-800-GOT-JUNK drives 75 miles from Fargo. We're on Belmont Road."
- **Against the free city vacuum:** "City pickup starts the third week of October and won't take bags. We rake to the curb before your street's week — or haul it all, any week you pick."
- **Against hourly junk:** "Flat price by the truck bed. No clock running."
- **In East Grand Forks:** don't fight the city's \$12 furniture / \$25 appliance pickups on price — sell cleanouts, same-day, no-lift, and what the city won't take. Show the Minnesota tax line on the estimate rather than eating it.

5

Ranking playbook — the local pack and organic, 30 / 60 / 90

How the pack is scored in 2026: GBP signals ≈25–32%, reviews ≈20%, behavior (clicks, calls, directions) ≈18%, links 15%, on-page 12%, citations 7%. Top individual factors: primary category, proximity to the searcher, rating, review count with text, recency, sustained review velocity, open at time of search. Two hard constraints: a home-based service business must hide its address (proximity still computes from it), and reviews may not be incentivized, gated, or solicited by staff quota.

Term	Now	Day-60 target (Nov 12)	Lever
leaf cleanup / leaf removal grand forks	Pack = mowing companies (54–89 reviews, no leaf page); organic = city page, Angi, doorways	Pack top 3, organic #1	/leaf-cleanup-grand-forks; GBP service "Fall leaf cleanup from \$160"; reviews that mention leaves (never dictated)
junk removal grand forks	Haul Away ≈110 reviews	Pack #2–3, organic top 3 among locals	Primary category Junk removal service; /junk-removal-grand-forks; LSA unit above the pack once GL is bound
yard debris / yard waste removal grand forks	LoadUp doorway	Organic #1–2	Section on the junk page + GBP service "Yard debris haul"
gutter cleaning grand forks	121 / 76 reviews	Pack entry, organic top 3	/gutter-cleaning-grand-forks; don't chase the gutter pack this year — sell gutters as the add-on
junk / leaves east grand forks	No real locals	Organic #1 ; pack depends on proximity	/east-grand-forks; EGF in service area; EGF street names and the Oct 5–9 cleanup week in copy
"pick it up e"	No third-party footprint	Page 1 owned by Sept 27	GBP + six citations

Day 0–7 (Sept 13–20): GBP complete, review link fixed, footprint created

- Primary category **Junk removal service** (year-round commercial intent; there is no leaf category). Secondaries: Lawn care service, Gutter cleaning service, Debris removal service. Four, no more.
- Address hidden; service area Grand Forks, East Grand Forks, Thompson, Manvel, Emerado, GFAFB.
- Hours Mon–Sat 7:00–20:00 through Nov 15 ("open at time of search"); special hours for Thanksgiving.
- Services with pricebook prices: Fall leaf cleanup from \$160 · Junk haul from \$59 · Full-bed haul from \$175 · Single-story gutter cleaning from \$135 · Leaves + gutters add-on from \$80 · Cleanout add-on +\$50.
- Description (≤750 characters) opening with the one-liner, naming both cities, the city vacuum, the \$50 deposit and the refuse list. Website pickitup.com/?s=gbp, appointment link pickitup.com/book?s=gbp — the source tag separates GBP bookings on the board.
- 20 photos now (truck, logo tile, work photos, gutter vacuum in use, a landfill scale ticket, tarp loads), then 2–3 a week from jobs. One post every Monday; the first is the promo.
- Seed 8 Q&A from the site FAQ: bags or loose, what we won't haul, two-story gutters, the deposit, do you do EGF, the block deal, city vacuum dates, same-day.
- Messaging on; reply within the hour.
- Read Reviews → Get more reviews → copy the `g.page/r/.../review` link into REVIEW_URL. Every done text, review text and email button reads that one constant.

On-page fixes (30 min): home H1 "Leaf cleanup & junk hauling in Grand Forks. We haul it. You don't."; East Grand Forks and the neighborhoods (Lincoln Park, Belmont Rd, Reeves Dr, Clover Dr, University Park) in body text; unique titles and descriptions for /book and /call; canonical on every route; footer NAP block identical to GBP; JSON-LD with geo, hours, service area as City objects, sameAs and the truck image. No aggregateRating — self-serving review markup is ineligible.

Citations, one afternoon, identical NAP: Bing Places (import from GBP, sync on), Apple Business Connect (service-area, no address), Yelp free page, Nextdoor business page (the hanger zones are Nextdoor neighborhoods — 47 in Grand Forks), Facebook page, BBB free profile (Haul Away is the only accredited GF junk business). Add each URL to sameAs. Skip paid Angi / HomeAdvisor / Thumbtack.

Day 8–30 (Sept 21 – Oct 13): five pages, first reviews, LSA application

URL	Title	What makes it not a doorway page
/leaf-cleanup-grand-forks	Leaf Cleanup & Removal in Grand Forks, ND — Done Before the City Vacuum Pick It Up E	Per-1,000 sf price table, rake-to-curb vs haul, curb rules, route weeks ("2026 tentatively the week of Oct 19"), neighborhoods, block deal
/junk-removal-grand-forks	Junk Removal & Hauling in Grand Forks, ND — Priced by the Truck Bed Pick It Up E	Bed-size table, refuse list, where it goes (landfill \$23 minimum, yard-waste site, Minnkota scrap — the disposal story LoadUp can't tell), yard-debris section, same-day

URL	Title	What makes it not a doorway page
/gutter-cleaning-grand-forks	Single-Story Gutter Cleaning in Grand Forks, ND — From the Ground, No Ladders Pick It Up E	\$135–215, add-on \$80–145, two-story handoff, why before freeze-up (ice dams), what the 120V vacuum does
/east-grand-forks	Leaf Cleanup, Junk Removal & Gutters in East Grand Forks, MN Pick It Up E	Fall Cleanup Oct 5–9 and what it does NOT take, the city's \$12/\$25 pickups vs our cleanouts, the MN tax line explained, EGF streets
/reviews	Pick It Up E Reviews — Grand Forks Customers	Real Google reviews quoted as text (no rating schema); ship once five exist

Each 400–700 unique words, pricebook numbers, its own FAQ + Service JSON-LD, three real photos with alt text, canonical, sitemap entry, footer link; request indexing the day it ships. Do not clone pages for Thompson / Manvel / Emerado — city-swap pages are doorway spam and still penalized.

The review engine — the 20% — and its rules

The ask is neutral and identical for every completed job, sent by text the morning after from the site (never a helper's phone), one follow-up at 48 hours, then stop. Never tied to the promo or block deal, never gated, never "mention Keaton", no helper or family reviews, never posted from your phone or hotspot (shared-device clustering trips Google's filter). After a block Saturday, stagger the asks over two or three mornings so the velocity looks organic. Reply to every review within 24 hours naming the service and the neighborhood. **Targets: 8 by Oct 13 · 20 by Nov 12 · 28 by Dec 12**, 3–6 a week and never more than five in one day. That needs about 40% of jobs to review ($n=0$) — if it reads under 30% on Oct 13, add the 48-hour follow-up and a QR card on the paper invoice.

Local Services Ads: the day GL binds and the EIN exists, apply for zip 58201 in Rubbish removal, Lawn care and Window cleaning (covers gutters). Screening takes 3–4 weeks, so a Sept 25 application puts the Google Guaranteed unit above the 3-pack for junk terms by late October. Weekly budget \$60, pay per lead. North Dakota availability is unverified — get a documented yes or no.

Day 31–60 (Oct 14 – Nov 12): behavior and links; the copy flips

- The hangers' QR (?s=dh), the Facebook posts and a priced GBP description drive branded searches and pack clicks (behavioral, $\approx 18\%$).
- Links a solo owner can actually get: a "before the city vacuum" fall-prep item pitched to the Grand Forks Herald and KNOX community desks; a landlord note to the Greater Grand Forks Apartment Association linking /landlords; the Chamber member listing; UND off-campus housing for December turnover hauls; the Senior Center's Silver Express newsletter if the ad is under ~\$50.
- Around Oct 20 the copy flips from "before the city vacuum" to "the vacuum missed it / gutters now that the leaves are down."
- Every Friday, run the seven searches from a phone in Grand Forks and log the 3-pack in the scorecard.

Day 61–90 (Nov 13 – Dec 12): hold velocity, bank the data

Review floor three a month from junk work; spring-plan copy in done texts; write the season's cost per lead by ?s= source into PRICEBOOK.md; GBP posts continue weekly (junk, cleanouts, "before the snow").

6

Customer engine — channels, cadence, scripts

Channel	Verdict	Cost	Leads / week at steady state (n=0)
Google Business Profile + reviews	Build — the only channel that ranks and books	\$0	2 until 10 reviews; 6–8 after
Door hangers (500 in hand; second 500 for Oct 2–3)	Keep	\$0.10–0.40 per house; 1–3% response over 1–3 weeks	5–15 responses per 500 → ~4/week for 3 weeks; break-even is one leaf job
Facebook groups (not Marketplace — service listings get pulled)	Build	\$0	3–5; 78% of homeowners pick the first responder — answer threads within the hour
Nextdoor page + Faves; \$10/day boost in the 4 hanger zones Oct 1–21	Build	≈\$210	2–3
Google Ads, leaf / yard-waste terms only, Oct 1–Nov 15	Run small	\$15/day; CPC ≈\$7.27, ≈20% click-to-lead, ≈\$36/lead	≈3
Local Services Ads	Apply when GL binds	\$60/week, per lead	2–3 once live
Block deal · repeat · two-visit plan	Build	\$0	2–4 from week 4
Property managers, realtors, apartment association	Build	Calls	1–2 from Oct 15; lumpy but high-ticket
Thumbtack (\$8–20/lead shared with 4–5 pros) · Angi (\$300/yr + \$15–55/lead) · Yelp Ads (\$150/mo min) · Herald print	Skip	—	—

Total 20–30 leads a week at peak → 8–12 jobs at a ~45% close, which is the capacity ceiling anyway. Paid spend at full run ≈ \$265 a week (Ads \$105 + Nextdoor \$70 + LSA \$60 + hangers ~\$30 amortized) against a \$234-a-week nut. **Kill rule for any paid channel:** 14-day cost per lead over \$60, close rate under 33%, or any source tag with zero bookings after \$150 spent → off.

The weekly cadence

- **Monday, 60 minutes at the desk:** reply to every review; GBP and Nextdoor photo post; staggered review asks (3–5 per morning); block-deal texts to this week's booked customers; work the follow-up queue on /jobs/customers; fill the scorecard (\$10); check ad cost per lead; move 25% of the week's collected to the tax account.
- **Thursday, 45 minutes:** Facebook posts on each group's permitted day; answer every "who does gutters / who hauls a couch" thread within the hour; two property-manager calls; cluster Saturday's route by street; confirm-the-day-before texts.
- **Saturday on the truck:** jobs clustered by street; 20–30 hangers on the block around each job; before/after photos; mileage by leg on the job page; say only "you'll get a text tomorrow" — no review pressure on the premises.

The customer's nine touches — what's built, what to add

#	Touch	When	Built / to add
1	Door hanger	Fridays, 9am–8pm, knob only	Built — QR carries ?s=dh
2	Estimate + booking	60 seconds	Built — hero widget → /book → \$50 Stripe deposit
3	Confirmation	The moment the deposit clears	Built — themed email + text with the ticket, the three "what happens next" steps, add-to-calendar
4	Confirm the day before	6–8 pm	Built — one-tap "confirm the date" text
5	Morning-of window	7:30 am job day	To add — the confirmation email promises it: "Morning, {first} — you're on today between 9 and 11. Nothing to prep. Silver crew cab."
6	On site	Inside the window	Built — crew "we're here" text; the 12-point card (\$7)
7	Done	Before the truck leaves the curb	Built — done text with invoice less deposit + review link; done email
8	Review nudge	Next morning 9 am (not two days), one nudge, then stop	To change — the follow-up queue fires at two days today
9a	Neighbor / block offer	Monday after the job	Built — "neighbor" text template

#	Touch	When	Built / to add
9b	Spring re-book	In done texts after Nov 1	To add — "Same yard next spring: the two-visit plan is \$280 for a standard lot, spring visit first. pickitupe.com/plan"

Scripts (plain text, under 320 characters where texted)

- **Review ask, next morning:** "Morning [First] — thanks for having us out yesterday. If we did right by you, a Google review helps the next neighbor find us. 30 seconds: [link] — Pick It Up E"
- **48-hour follow-up, once:** "[First], one nudge and then we'll leave you be — the review link again: [link]. Thanks either way."
- **Block deal, Monday after booking:** "Hi [First] — we're on [Street] on [Saturday]. If a neighbor books the same day you both get \$25 off (\$40 each at three houses). Send them pickitupe.com. — Pick It Up E"
- **Gutter add-on, the day before a leaf job (after Oct 20):** "While we're there tomorrow: single-story gutters from the ground, \$80–110 on top of the leaves. Reply YES and it's on the ticket."
- **Promo close, Sept 19 / Oct 9:** "Last day to lock 20% off (up to \$75) on fall leaves, junk or gutters — price shows before you book: pickitupe.com. Rate locks now, date is yours to pick. — Pick It Up E"
- **Property-manager call:** "I run a one-truck haul-out and yard crew in town. For turnovers I do haul-out, gutters and yard in one visit, flat price per stop, net-15 invoice, and I'm on Belmont Road so same-day is real. Who handles your December turnovers?" — Goldmark 701-780-9901 · Hampton 701-775-5544 · IMM 701-746-9551 · Elite 701-746-7368 · Dakota Commercial 701-757-4603 · Oxford Realty 701-772-2522.
- **Facebook group post:** "Leaves, junk, single-story gutters — Grand Forks and EGF. Price shows on the site before you call (a 5,000 sq ft lot runs \$160–230), book in a minute, \$50 deposit comes off the bill. pickitupe.com/?s=fb"

Groups to join: Greater Grand Forks Buy & Sell (58K) · Grand Forks Buy&Sell (53K) · Grand Forks Raves Reviews and RANTS (24K) · Grand Forks Rants, Raves, & Reviews (17K — self-promo only on its designated day) · the public "without dirty deletes" group (6K) · Grand Forks ND Buy Sell Trade (9K). One plain post per group per week, photo of the truck bed, price anchor from the pricebook. The owner's personal profile shares the page post — that is the East Grand Forks reach too.

7 Operations — the truck-day, drop sites, crew rules, the phone

Saturday shape, leaf season

- 6:45 load:** blower, rakes, two tarps, 20 bags, 20–30 hangers, gutter vacuum only if a YES came back.
- 7:15–10:00 junk first:** two half-bed jobs in one zone → one landfill run, on the scale by 10:30 (Saturday closes at 11:00).
- 10:45–16:30 leaf block:** three or four houses on one street. In a route week, rake to the curb — no haul, no dump run. Outside route weeks or in EGF, tarp-and-haul: about one yard-waste run per 1.5 loads (a 7,500 sf lot is 1–2 heaped beds of loose leaves — n=0, measure it on job one).
- Log each leg on the job page as you go (home → job → drop → next job); photos before and after; final number before anything moves.
- Home by 17:00. Say "text tomorrow", nothing else.

Weekday evenings (Tue/Thu 17:00–19:00): one junk pickup or one gutter job; the load stays in the bed and goes to the landfill next day before 4 or first thing Saturday. No weekday leaf hauls — no daylight after mid-October and no yard-waste hours confirmed.

Route-density rules

- A lone booking in a new zone waits for a second before it gets a Saturday — unless it is a full-bed junk or a leaf + gutter bundle.
- Every booked address triggers 20–30 hangers on that block the same Saturday with the block deal.
- Target 1.5 jobs per dump run; the board's same-day clusters show it. Two half-beds on one landfill run save \$23 and about 14 miles.
- Helper only on days with two or more leaf/bundle jobs; junk and gutters run solo (a helper raises the owner's take on a leaf lot and lowers it on junk and gutters — \$8).

Drop sites (already placed in the app — Books > Setup > Where loads go)

Debris	Site	From the hanger zones	Cost	Hours
Junk, furniture, household waste	Grand Forks Landfill, 2701 N 69th St	6–8 mi, 14–17 min	\$23 minimum (covers ~770 lb at \$59.54/ton); inert \$30.42/ton; tires \$10–125. A heaped 2.5 cu yd bed of household junk is ~400 lb — every load pays the minimum, so the lever is loads per run	Mon–Fri 8–4, Sat 8–11, Sun closed
Leaves, yard waste	Public Works yard-waste site, 724 N 47th St (commercial haulers must use this, the landfill, or DeMers & 5th Ave S)	4–6 mi, 10–13 min	No fee published — modeled \$12 a load; call 701-738-8740 to confirm	Not posted — ask
Scrap, appliances	Minnkota Recycling, 2004 DeMers Ave (701-746-9600)	2–3 mi	May pay for metal; appliance/freon fee unpublished. Separate metal in the bed — it skips the landfill fee	Ask
EGF leaves (commercial)	EGF Public Works, 1001 2nd St NE	4 mi	\$100/yr + \$10 a visit — or haul EGF leaves to the GF yard-waste site	Mon–Fri 7–3:30 only

Never present a commercial load as a resident's free household drop-off. Keep every scale ticket — snap it into Books, it lands as a dump fee on the job.

The 12-point card in the truck

- Arrive inside the texted window; if 15+ late, send "running late" from the crew portal first.
- Park on the street or driveway — never the lawn (ruts are the #1 fall complaint).
- Knock once; no answer → "we're here" text; start on leaves/gutters; junk inside needs someone 18+.
- 60-second walk with the customer (or a photo text): confirm scope, point out anything on the refuse list, check for two-story gutters — hand off, don't climb.
- Say the final number before anything moves.** "Estimate was \$240–345; it's a standard lot, so \$285 less your \$50 — \$235."
- Before photo, wide, no faces.
- Leaves: rake, tarp, load, blow beds and walk, sweep the drive, close the gate. Gutters: vacuum, flush downspouts, bag the muck. Junk: load, strap, sweep the spot.

Crew rules

- Helpers see no money — the crew portal hides estimates, deposits, payments and notes by design.
- Clock in and out in the portal; every hour of the job including the drive is paid.
- Texts go through the one-tap buttons so they log on the job.
- No helper drives their own car on a job until hired-and-non-owned auto is on the policy.
- Helpers never solicit reviews. No family reviews.
- Nobody works a shift before WSI coverage is active and the payroll steps in \$9 are done — the uninsured penalty is \$10,000 plus \$100 a day.

The phone

701-213-3969 is the site number and the one on the hangers; 218-779-2553 stays reserved. When the EIN lands, the missed-call line goes live

8. After photo from the same spot.
9. Collect the balance on the spot (card link, cash, check, Venmo — recorded on the job page).
10. One line: "You'll get a text from us tomorrow morning — that's it." No review pressure on the premises.
11. Tap "done" in the crew portal; the owner marks it done → the done email goes.
12. Log mileage by leg before the next stop.

in two stages (PHONE-LINE.md): first voice — the greeting spells out the website, records a message, opens a lead on the board and emails you the transcript; then, once toll-free verification clears, the caller gets the booking link by text and you get the alert on your cell. Reply to every lead within the hour.

Weather rule

Book leaf jobs "weather-permitting". Plan the leaf season to end Nov 8; hold Nov 9–20 as overflow; after Nov 15 the calendar is junk and gutters.

8

Money — what a job is worth, and how many jobs make what profit

Every number here is computed by scripts/plan-model.mjs from the pricebook, the city's 2026 rate sheet and the monthly obligations in Books. Change an input there, never a number on this page. Hours are n=0 until the crew clock has ten real jobs.

The nut — what the business must clear every month, working or not

Monthly obligation	Per month
Truck payment (personal, business must cover)	\$550
Extended warranty	\$220
Progressive auto (\$450 / 6 mo)	\$75
Supabase Pro + Netlify + domain	\$48
General liability (NEXT quote, not bound)	\$85
Twilio line	\$5
Phone share (business use of the cell)	\$30
Total the business must clear	\$1,013

The truck, warranty and auto insurance are personal obligations the business has to earn; the standard mileage rate is the whole vehicle deduction. Commercial auto is not in this list yet — add the Progressive quote the day it lands (a \$100–150 delta moves break-even from 5 to about 6 jobs).

What each job keeps (solo)

Service	Ticket*	Dump	Truck	Card	Bags	Keeps	Hours	Keeps / hour
Leaf cleanup · small city lot (5,000 sf)	\$180	\$12	\$9	\$4	\$4	\$150	2.75	\$55
Leaf cleanup · standard lot (7,500 sf)	\$271	\$12	\$9	\$6	\$4	\$240	3.5	\$69
Leaf cleanup · large / corner (12,000 sf)	\$386	\$12	\$9	\$8	\$4	\$353	4.9	\$72
Junk · one piece or bags	\$69	\$28	\$9	\$2	\$4	\$25	1.5	\$17
Junk · half the bed	\$147	\$28	\$9	\$4	\$4	\$102	2	\$51
Junk · full bed	\$203	\$28	\$9	\$5	\$4	\$157	2.75	\$57
Gutters · single-story, from the ground	\$137	\$9	\$9	\$3	\$4	\$112	1.7	\$66
Leaf standard + gutters while we're here	\$361	\$12	\$9	\$7	\$4	\$329	4.25	\$77

* Ticket = midpoint of the pricebook range, after the promo on 30% of jobs and the block credit on 15%. "Keeps" = ticket minus dump, truck miles at the IRS rate, card fees and consumables — before the nut and before tax. Read the last column: the single-item junk job is the one that doesn't pay unless it's chained; the leaf + gutter bundle is the best hour you can sell.

Blended fall mix (solo): \$246 ticket · \$34 variable cost · **\$213 kept per job** · 3.23 h per job including drive and dump. **With a helper on every job:** \$246 ticket · \$79 variable cost (incl. \$45 helper) · **\$168 kept** · 2.24 h per job. Break-even: **5 jobs a month solo, 7 with a helper.**

Job type	Share of fall jobs
Leaf cleanup · standard lot (7,500 sf)	45%
Leaf cleanup · small city lot (5,000 sf)	12%
Leaf cleanup · large / corner (12,000 sf)	10%
Leaf standard + gutters while we're here	8%
Gutters · single-story, from the ground	5%
Junk · half the bed	10%
Junk · full bed	5%
Junk · one piece or bags	5%

Jobs → profit, per month (solo)

Jobs / month	Revenue	Variable	Fixed nut	Pre-tax profit	Margin	After 30% tax	Hours	After-tax \$/h
4	\$985	\$134	\$1,013	−\$162	-16%	−\$162	12.92	−\$13
6	\$1,477	\$201	\$1,013	\$263	18%	\$184	19.38	\$10
8	\$1,970	\$268	\$1,013	\$689	35%	\$482	25.84	\$19
10	\$2,462	\$335	\$1,013	\$1,114	45%	\$780	32.3	\$24
15	\$3,693	\$503	\$1,013	\$2,178	59%	\$1,524	48.45	\$31
20	\$4,924	\$670	\$1,013	\$3,241	66%	\$2,269	64.6	\$35
30	\$7,387	\$1,005	\$1,013	\$5,368	73%	\$3,758	96.9	\$39
40	\$9,849	\$1,340	\$1,013	\$7,495	76%	\$5,247	129.2	\$41

Jobs → profit, per month, with a helper on every job

Jobs / month	Revenue	Variable (incl. helper)	Pre-tax profit	After tax	Your hours	After-tax \$/h
4	\$985	\$315	−\$343	−\$343	8.96	−\$38
6	\$1,477	\$472	−\$8	−\$8	13.44	−\$1
8	\$1,970	\$629	\$327	\$229	17.92	\$13
10	\$2,462	\$787	\$662	\$464	22.4	\$21
15	\$3,693	\$1,180	\$1,500	\$1,050	33.6	\$31
20	\$4,924	\$1,574	\$2,338	\$1,636	44.8	\$37
30	\$7,387	\$2,360	\$4,013	\$2,809	67.2	\$42
40	\$9,849	\$3,147	\$5,689	\$3,982	89.6	\$44

A helper costs you about \$1,000 a month at 40 jobs and gives back your Saturdays: the after-tax profit is lower but your hours drop by a third. Put the helper on leaf days only and you keep most of both.

The fall season (9 weeks, solo)

Jobs / week	Jobs (9 wks)	Revenue	Fixed (2.1 mo)	Pre-tax	After tax	Hours	After-tax \$/h
2	18	\$4,432	\$2,106	\$1,723	\$1,206	58.14	\$21
4	36	\$8,864	\$2,106	\$5,552	\$3,886	116.28	\$33
6	54	\$13,296	\$2,106	\$9,381	\$6,567	174.42	\$38
8	72	\$17,728	\$2,106	\$13,210	\$9,247	232.56	\$40
10	90	\$22,160	\$2,106	\$17,038	\$11,927	290.7	\$41

The fall season with a helper

Jobs / week	Jobs (9 wks)	Revenue	Pre-tax	After tax	Your hours	After-tax \$/h
6	54	\$13,296	\$6,942	\$4,859	120.96	\$40
8	72	\$17,728	\$9,957	\$6,970	161.28	\$43
10	90	\$22,160	\$12,973	\$9,081	201.6	\$45
14	126	\$31,024	\$19,005	\$13,303	282.24	\$47

The winter escrow — the number the fall has to produce

The nut runs all winter with no revenue. December through March is four months × \$1,013 ≈ **\$4,050**, plus a \$1,000 repair reserve, plus November's nut and the ≈\$1,340 marketing run. Call it **\$7,400 after tax** banked by Nov 15 — that is **about 60 jobs** in the solo ladder above, or 6–7 a week for nine weeks. From Oct 1, every kept dollar above the current month's nut goes to the escrow until it holds that number; the two-visit plan prepayments in November and December are the cushion on top.

Truck-day models (n=0 hours; cash kept after direct cost and a 25% set-aside)

Day	Jobs	Collected	Direct cost	Set-aside	Cash kept	Owner hours
Leaf block, curb-pile, solo (route week)	3 × 7,500 sf @ \$245 block price	\$735	\$34	\$184	\$517	8.0
Leaf block with a helper	4 × \$245	\$980	\$43 + \$144 helper	\$245	\$548	7.5
Haul day (pre-Oct 19 / EGF)	2 leaf @ \$285 + 1 half bed	\$730	\$88	\$183	\$459	8.3
Junk + gutter day (November)	2 half + 1 full + 1 gutter, 2 landfill runs	\$690	\$99	\$173	\$418	6.0

A full Saturday keeps \$420–550. Two Saturdays cover the month; the third and fourth are profit and escrow. A \$40-off block of three beats a full-price lone job per owner-hour because the drive and dump legs are shared — and the curb-pile in a route week is the best hour there is.

Cash rules — every Monday on Books

1. 25% of every dollar collected moves to the tax account (kept at 25%, not 18% — the portfolio section says why). Minnesota sales and solid-waste tax collected on EGF jobs goes to a second account — it was never yours.
2. Deposits stay in operating and count toward the nut the week they land; a September pre-book funds September.
3. Reserve first: the first \$1,000 kept after the September nut is the repair/permit reserve.
4. Winter escrow from Oct 1 (above). The nut is paid on the 1st from operating; keep a two-month floor before touching the remaining \$3,138 of the equipment budget.
5. No equipment purchase before ten clocked jobs, and only when a roadmap trigger (\$11) fires.
6. Paid marketing capped at \$265 a week, only Oct 1–Nov 15, each channel with its kill rule.
7. Stripe pays out weekly; cash, check and Venmo are logged the same day so "collected" on the board stays true. Scale tickets through the receipt scanner the same day.

Tax note. The 25%-of-collected set-aside is a rule, not the liability. The model taxes profit at 30% (self-employment tax plus your federal and ND rates on top of the \$55k W-2, net of the half-SE and QBI deductions); with the \$1,862 of equipment deductible in year one and the 2026 mileage, the actual bill on a \$6,000 season is nearer \$1,500–2,000 — the CPA files the position and the surplus releases at filing. The 2026 loss or profit lands on the same 1040 as the W-2.

9

Compliance & risk — dated, with cost

When	Item	Why (source in Appendix B)	Cost	Status
Sept 14–16	Bind general liability \$1M/\$2M (NEXT)	The hauler permit, LSA screening and landlord COIs all need the certificate	≈\$85/mo	Not bound
Sept 14–16	Private-hauler permit , City of Grand Forks	City Code §13-0406.1: hauling "rubbish, construction refuse and/or white goods" for others on city streets needs a council-approved permit; "rubbish" is defined to include lawn clippings, tree trimmings and discarded furniture; application needs a performance bond and proof of liability; penalty up to \$500 an offense. §13-0406(4): putrescible garbage may not be hauled privately at all.	\$75 (2026) + bond (unpublished; small permit bonds typically \$100–300/yr)	Ask the council date Monday. Until it issues: rake-to-curb inside the city, haul only outside city limits, take deposits for later dates
Before hanging	Written ruling on literature drops	Ordinance 4707 (Ch. XXI Art. 12): door-to-door sales need a \$500 license + \$5,000 bond + 7–14-day background check; no express exemption for leaving printed literature; up to \$500 a day. If "yes": pivot to handoffs, Nextdoor, GBP; check EGF's ordinance. If "no": 9am–8pm, knob only, skip posted houses (§21-1210(K)).	\$0	Email sent Monday
Always	Knob only, never the mailbox	18 U.S.C. §1725 — up to \$5,000 per offense	\$0	Rule in print/DOOR-HANGER.md
~Sept 18	EIN at irs.gov	Gates WSI, Job Service ND, ND withholding, MN Tax ID, Twilio verification, the bank account	\$0, 10 min	Waiting on SOS
Before the next paid haul	Commercial auto (or business-use endorsement) on the Sierra; hired & non-owned if a helper drives	A personal auto policy typically excludes hauling for pay — a claim during a paid haul is deniable	Unknown until quoted	Largest uninsured exposure today
Before the first EGF job	Minnesota Tax ID (e-Services) with East Grand Forks and Polk County local taxes	MN taxes fall cleanup / raking, gutter cleaning and junk removal: 8.375% combined sales tax on leaf and gutter work (6.875 + 1.0 EGF + 0.5 Polk); junk hauls fall under the 9.75% residential Solid Waste Management Tax on the same return; separately stated scrap to a recycler is exempt; no dollar threshold. North Dakota taxes none of these services.	\$0, 30 min	Code: tax line keyed off the geocoded state; until registered, don't accept EGF bookings
Before a helper's first shift	(1) WSI coverage active before day one, \$250 minimum premium; (2) Job Service ND within 20 days of first hire — liability at \$1,500 wages in a quarter (≈83 h at \$18) or 20 weeks; 1.00% on the first \$46,600; (3) ND withholding account, Form 306; (4) W-4 + I-9 day one, new-hire report within 20 days; (5) 941/940 via EFTPS or a payroll service	Uninsured penalty \$10,000 + \$100/day; W-2, never 1099 — you schedule, supervise and hand them tools	\$250 WSI + payroll	Crew tab checklist exists; add the \$1,500/quarter trigger
Now	Vehicle policy: record the Sierra's door-jamb GVWR; no trailer on any Minnesota job	GF→EGF is interstate; truck + trailer with combined GVWR ≥10,001 lb is a federal CMV (USDOT number, driver file). Truck alone stays under. ND intrastate is exempt to 26,000 lb combined.	\$0	Trailer fine on ND-only jobs
Ongoing	Texting: transactional only, "Reply STOP to opt out", honor opt-outs within 10 business days	TCPA consent rules; no promo blasts to call-back numbers without written consent	\$0	Built into the phone line
Ongoing	Reviews: no incentives, no gating, no staff quotas, no dictated content, no family/helper reviews	Google Maps contribution policy (staff quotas explicit since Apr 2026)	\$0	Compliant — keep it
Once	Landfill Waste Profile Form; keep scale tickets	§13-0406.1(6): the permit grants no dumping right until landfill rules and fees are met	\$0	—
Verified not needed	ND contractor license · GF building-trade licenses · ND sales tax permit for GF jobs	Not construction (NDCC 43-07, \$4,000/job threshold never reached); ND does not tax these services	\$0	—

Open risks not yet priced

- Bond amount and council timing for the hauler permit — if the cycle runs past Oct 1, paid hauling inside the city is illegal during peak; the mitigation is rake-to-curb jobs and out-of-city hauls.
- The yard-waste drop fee for commercial loads (modeled \$12, could be \$0 or \$23), Minnkota's appliance charge, the WSI class rate, the commercial-auto premium — each moves a job by \$10–25.
- Review conversion is $n=0$; the junk pack incumbent's ≈ 110 reviews cannot be passed in 60 days regardless.
- Capacity, not demand, is the ceiling — without PTO in the vacuum weeks or a helper on leaf days the base case slips toward 35 jobs.
- Weather ends the season on its own schedule; a late vacuum start compresses the window.
- LSA availability in North Dakota is unverified; without it the junk lane stays #2–3.
- The 2026 city leaf-vacuum routes are not posted; copy that promises a route week before the map exists risks being wrong on the page meant to rank.

10

Scorecard — twelve numbers, every Monday

One row per week. Until the app has a scorecard page, keep it as a sheet named *Scorecard* in the Pick It Up E – Ops folder, and put a repeating Monday 8:00 reminder on the phone. Everything reads off the board, Books, Search Console or GBP Performance — nothing needs a new tool.

#	Metric	Read it from	Target
1	Google reviews, cumulative	GBP	8 by Oct 13 · 20 by Nov 12 · 28 by Dec 12
2	Reviews this week (velocity)	GBP	3–6/week Oct–Nov; ≥3/month after; never more than 5 in a day
3	Review conversion (reviews ÷ completed jobs, trailing 3 weeks)	GBP ÷ board	≥40% — if under 30% on Oct 13, add the 48-h follow-up and the invoice QR
4	Pages indexed	Search Console	6 by Sept 20 · 11 by Sept 30
5	Pack position on the 7 tracked searches (phone, in Grand Forks, Fridays)	Manual log	Leaf top 3 by Nov 12 · junk #2–3 · EGF terms #1 organic
6	Search Console impressions and clicks for leaf / junk / gutter + Grand Forks	Search Console	Up week over week; ≥10 clicks/week by Nov 1
7	GBP actions (calls + directions + website clicks)	GBP Performance	≥15/week by Oct 20
8	GBP photos cumulative / posts this week	GBP	≥40 photos by Oct 13 · 1 post every Monday
9	Leads by source (dh / gbp / fb / ads / call / plan)	Board — bookings.source	20–30/week at peak; hangers 1–3% of 500
10	Jobs completed · jobs per dump run · same-street share · owner hours	Board + crew clock	6–7 solo / 8–10 with helper · ≥1.5 per run · ≥50% same street · real hours replace the n=0 estimates
11	Cash: collected this week · cash kept this Saturday · 25% moved · MN tax held · escrow balance	Books	≥\$450 kept per full Saturday · set-aside moved every Monday · nut covered by the 1st · escrow \$7,400 by Nov 15
12	Paid cost per lead and close rate (Ads, Nextdoor, LSA) · reply time on every lead	Ad dashboards ÷ bookings · board	Scale under \$45 CPL and ≥40% close; pause over \$60 or under 33% · 100% of leads answered under 4 hours

"Rank first" means, numerically: pack position 1–3 and organic position 1 on the leaf and East Grand Forks terms, logged weekly, by Nov 12. Search Console's position export is the free tracker for organic; the Friday phone check is the only honest tracker for the pack.

11

Roadmap through spring 2027, with decision triggers

- **Sept 13 → Oct 13 — rank foundation, promo close.** GBP complete, review link fixed, six citations, five pages shipped, LSA applied, hauler permit filed, GL bound, EIN, MN Tax ID, first 500 hangers (after the Finance ruling), second 500 hung Oct 2–3 with the "before the city vacuum" headline. Goal: 15 booked jobs, 8 reviews, 4 property-manager conversations, LSA verified or a documented "not available".
- **Oct 14 → Nov 12 — peak.** Route weeks from the city's 2026 map; gutter add-on text on every leaf job after Oct 20; block days at 3+ houses per street; landlord-pack pilot with two managers; "before the snow" junk push in the first week of November. Goal: 8–12 jobs a week, 20 reviews, 2 property-manager accounts, 5 two-visit plans sold.
- **Nov 13 → Dec 12 — close-out.** Ads and Nextdoor off Nov 15; done texts switch to the two-visit plan; apartment-association December meeting; realtor-association affiliate join if dues are under ~\$300; UND semester-end turnover hauls; cost per lead by channel into PRICEBOOK.md. Goal: 20 plans sold, 28 reviews, 3 recurring landlord accounts, one documented winner and one loser among paid channels.
- **Dec 13 → Mar 31 — winter: snow contracts and junk.** Snow on the 1-inch trigger for the prepaid route (if the Oct 15 / Oct 25 gates passed); winter haul between events; review floor 3/month; monthly GBP post; property-manager turnover hauls; the season's clock data rewrites the hours in §8; commercial auto and WSI in place before the first spring helper; watch for the 2027 Spring Cleanup dates.
- **Apr 1 → May 31 — spring.** The yard window is Apr 16 – May 15; plan customers first; junk demand pulls into the two weeks before each city cleanup week; re-run the review engine; Ads on "spring cleanup grand forks" only if fall CPL was under \$45.

Decision	Do it when	Don't when
Second helper	The crew clock shows owner site hours over 20/week for three weeks AND the board shows a leaf backlog over 5 days AND there are 2+ leaf/bundle jobs per truck-day	Fall net is under \$5k, or WSI / Job Service registrations aren't active
Trailer or dump trailer	4+ two-trip junk jobs a month for two months, or full-bed jobs exceed 40% of junk volume, AND the two-month nut floor survives the purchase	Any work crosses the river — a trailer makes GF→EGF a federal CMV. ND-only use is fine
Mowing	20+ two-visit plans sold AND 15+ fall customers ask unprompted AND 10 subscribers on one route inside the hanger zones (GF mowing prices at \$45–49 a visit — it only pays as a dense route)	It would put you against Meticulous (61), PRO Land (89) and Lawn King (54) on their turf for a \$45 ticket
Extend the promo to Oct 10	Now — the hangers go out after the printed date	The calendar already shows 8+ jobs a week
Scale Ads to \$20/day	14-day CPL under \$45 and close rate ≥40%	After Nov 1
Google Ads on "junk removal"	The calendar has holes in a week (CPC ≈\$12, CPL ≈\$58)	While leaf demand fills the truck
BBB accreditation	20+ reviews and a landlord account asks for it	Before the LLC is active
Take the shed (Menards 10×12 kit, ≈\$2,277 after rebate)	First \$2,500 collected, or April before the mowing decision — and only if the 10-ft space clears eaves and the city setback	Out of the \$5,000 equipment budget — it's a separate capital decision
Drop a paid channel	14-day CPL over \$60, close under 33%, or \$150 spent with zero bookings	—

12

What not to do — the cash-killers

1. **Do not add a service during the fall peak.** No mowing, no two-story gutters, no demo, no holiday lights. Each one is a new tool, a new permit question and a lower-margin hour. **One reversal, decided Sept 13 and worked in the next section:** residential snow (driveway + city sidewalk + steps) as a prepaid seasonal contract inside the fall route, walk-behind blowers only, no plow on the truck, behind three gates — GL covers snow and ice in writing, the warranty contract is read, 10 contracts prepaid by Oct 15. §11 and that section hold the only triggers that reopen anything else.
2. **Do not take a lone job in a new zone on a Saturday** unless it is a full-bed junk or a bundle. Wait for the second booking or hang 30 hangers on that block first.
3. **Do not haul a single half-bed to the landfill alone** when a second is bookable within 48 hours — that is \$23 and about 14 miles thrown away per run.
4. **Do not touch mailboxes, hang on posted houses, or knock** — the ordinance exposure is \$500 a day and the federal one is \$5,000 an offense.
5. **Do not run paid hauls inside Grand Forks before the §13-0406.1 permit issues.** Take deposits, schedule for after.
6. **Do not pay for shared leads** (Thumbtack, Angi) or for print. Do not turn on Google Ads for junk terms while leaves fill the truck.
7. **Do not stack deals, invent a referral bonus, or discount for reviews.** The block deal is the referral program and Google bans review incentives.
8. **Do not buy equipment before ten clocked jobs.** The \$3,138 left in the budget is the winter cushion until a trigger fires.
9. **Do not hire before the EIN, WSI and Job Service ND are done.** Do not put a helper on junk or gutter days — they lose money there.
10. **Do not take an East Grand Forks job before the Minnesota Tax ID exists,** and never a curbside-only pickup in Minnesota.
11. **Do not tow a trailer across the river for pay.**
12. **Do not book leaf work after Nov 8 as anything but "weather permitting".**
13. **Do not re-add a booking form to the home page, re-mount the falling leaves, or put the black-field truck photo back** — settled decisions.
14. **Do not spend the tax set-aside or the winter escrow on marketing.** Ever.

THE VALLEYS, THE TAXES, THE PORTFOLIO

Peaks, valleys, taxes and where the money goes

This is a two-peak business: six weeks of leaves in the fall, six weeks of yards in the spring, and seven months in between where the current pricebook sells almost nothing while the nut runs anyway — **seven × \$1,013 ≈ \$7,100**. Three research crews (off-season lines, the tax code, the cash waterfall) and one portfolio crew worked it against the ground truth, with every load-bearing fact verified against the primary source. Four questions, answered in order: how to fill the valleys, how to keep more of each dollar legally, where every collected dollar goes, and how this business sits next to the trading account, LuxeForge and a future rental on one tax return. Filed positions go to the CPA; this section is built to make that meeting a short one.

The decisions

1. **The valleys are covered three ways, in this order:** the escrow the fall builds (\$5,065 by Oct 31 in the realistic case, \$D), the two-visit plans sold in November (10 medium plans = \$2,800 ≈ the December–February nut), and three off-season lines that cost almost nothing to open — residential **snow** as a prepaid seasonal contract inside the fall route, **winter haul** (junk, estate and realtor cleanouts, UND turnovers) with no code at all, and for 2027 a **power-rake add-on** on the spring visit plus **pressure washing** in June–August.
2. **Standing decision reversed, on the record:** §12 rule 1 said "no snow". It is reversed for one product only — driveway + city sidewalk + steps, sold prepaid, capped at 30 houses on streets we already work, cleared with walk-behind blowers. **No plow goes on the Sierra.** Three gates before a dollar is spent: the GL policy covers residential snow and ice in writing, the extended-warranty contract has been read for commercial-use language, and 10 contracts are prepaid by Oct 15.
3. **Tax:** the app's **25%-of-collected set-aside stays** (a builder argued 18%; the portfolio overrides it — \$D). The Milwaukee kit is expensed under the de minimis safe harbor; the truck stays on standard mileage plus the business share of the loan interest; an exclusive-use home office is opened now because it turns home→job miles into business miles; the brother is a fully taxable W-2 employee; a Solo 401(k) with Roth deferrals beats a SEP; no S-corp before ~\$60k of net; Minnesota registrations before any East Grand Forks job.
4. **Cash:** every collected dollar runs one waterfall — MN tax pass-through → 25% tax → job costs → the nut → winter escrow → \$1,000 repair reserve → owner draw, once a month. Extra principal on the 10% truck loan comes only from what is left after that (**+\$200/mo saves \$2,378 and 19 months**). Equipment must pay back 1.5× inside the season it is first used.
5. **Portfolio:** one bank account and one Stripe account per legal entity — **the Stripe split from LuxeForge happens this week**; trading is filed as an investor on Schedule D (no self-employment tax, no QBI, no entity, and the \$475 window for 2026 already closed); a rental starts in your own name behind a landlord policy and an umbrella; LuxeForge gets its own LLC the day a subscriber can pay.

A. The year as it actually is

Window	Demand on the current pricebook	What sells	What carries the nut
Sept 14 – Oct 5	Leads, few completions — leaves are up, the hauler permit is pending, the W-2 owns the weekdays	Deposits on October dates, gutters, hauls outside city limits	Deposits + the W-2
Oct 6 – Nov 8	The fall peak — first hard freeze to the median 1-inch snow	70–95 jobs with leave from Oct 5, 40–55 with the W-2 kept	Itself; fills the escrow and the repair reserve in October
Nov 9 – 30	The tail — gutters until the debris freezes, junk "before the snow", plan sales at every done text	10–15 jobs + two-visit plans + the first snow contracts	Itself
Dec – Mar	Dead on the pricebook	Winter haul \$670–\$1,700/mo (n=0); snow contracts if sold; UND turnover week Dec 14–18; gift cards	Escrow draws \$1,013 on the 1st, four times
Apr 16 – May 31	The spring peak — plan visits, spring cleanups, the two weeks before each city cleanup week, UND move-out May 14	≈40 jobs (n=0) + power-rake add-on + landlord turns	Itself; refills the escrow to \$3,039 for the summer
Jun – Aug	Dead, again	Pressure washing from June 2027; storm brush and contractor dump runs as they come	Escrow refilled by spring

The \$8 escrow figure (\$7,400 by Nov 15) is the same money as this section's \$5,065 escrow + \$1,000 repair reserve + the ≈\$1,340 marketing run paid as it goes. One number, two ways of splitting it.

B. Filling the valleys — thirteen lines scored, three built, the rest killed

Line	Fills	Start-up	Drag (permit / insurance / tax)	Verdict
Residential snow — driveway + city sidewalk + steps, prepaid season	Dec–Mar	~\$1,550 per blower, second only after contract #15	GL must cover snow & ice; no sales tax in ND or MN	Build — winter 2026–27

Line	Fills	Start-up	Drag (permit / insurance / tax)	Verdict
Winter haul — junk, estate/realtor cleanouts, appliances, Marketplace delivery, UND turns	Dec–Mar	\$0 — copy and one size alias	\$13-0406.1 permit; MN SWM 9.75% in EGF	Build — copy, not code
Spring power-rake add-on on the plan visit	Apr 16–May 31	Rent a dethatcher the first spring	None in ND	Build — spring 2027
Pressure washing — driveway, walks, single-story siding from the ground	Jun–Aug	\$1,500–\$2,500 rig, April 2027	MN "building cleaning" tax likely in EGF — unverified	Build — summer 2027
Property-manager retainer (grounds + haul)	All year	COIs, snow-liability wording	Slowest first dollar on the board	Pitch Feb 2027 with a winter of references
Holiday lights	Nov–Jan	Inventory	Roofline clips are ladder work — the one thing the brand promises not to do; lands on the leaf finish; three GF incumbents	Kill
Christmas-tree pickup	Jan	\$0	The city collects trees free through Jan 15	Kill — "we carry it out" is a free touch in the snow plan
Mulch + bed edging	May–Jun	Trailer	A Sierra bed carries ~2 yd: \$150–\$190 a trip	Kill for 2027 — trailer economics
Storm brush, contractor dump runs, appliance-only, Marketplace delivery	Any	\$0	—	Already priced by the junk ladder — GBP categories and copy, not services

Scored on revenue in Greater Grand Forks, recurrence, speed to the first dollar, fit with what we already hold (the truck, the brother, 65+ households in the oldest neighborhoods, a site that sells prepaid plans through Stripe, the no-ladder brand), start-up cost and drag. Every demand figure is n=0 until the Oct 1 text goes out. Any line that needs a ladder, a trailer or a second truck is not a 2026–27 line.

Line A — Snow: driveway + city sidewalk + steps, winter 2026–27

Why it wins. The ordinance sells it: City Code 16-0301 gives owners 24 hours after a snowfall to clear the sidewalk or the city clears it and bills the utility account (last reported at \$1 a running foot — stale, confirm with Streets 701-738-8740). Dumping snow in the street is its own offense (16-0317). The NWS normal is **14.7 days a year with an inch or more**; 2025 had 8. A prepaid season priced on 14.7 pushes is very profitable in an 8-push year and underwater only past ~20. At least ten operators sell snow in GF, all tractor-mounted: a tractor clears a driveway in two minutes and does not do the steps, the front walk or the hydrant path. Our slot is the hand-finished lot on the streets we already rake — and 14% of Grand Forks is 65+, concentrated in exactly those neighborhoods; the Senior Center's "Service Providers for Seniors" list (701-772-7245) is the referral channel.

Offer	Test price (n=0)	Rule
Per push — driveway + city sidewalk + front steps, 1-inch / 24-hour trigger	\$40–\$50	Inside the \$30–\$75 national band; corner lot +\$10–\$15; the berm after the city plow is included (gfsnow includes it — match, don't undercut)
Seasonal prepaid, Nov 1 – Apr 1	\$450–\$550	Inside \$350–\$600; break-even vs per-push at 10–11 pushes; non-refundable once the season starts (industry norm); never stacks with the fall promo or the block credit
Cap	30 contracts	Two walk-behind crews × ~25 min a stop × 30 stops ≈ 6¼ h each inside the 24-hour window. Past 30, per-push only. Sell seasonal only where ≥3 contracts sit on a street or two adjoining streets

At the cap: 30 × \$450–\$550 = **\$13,500–\$16,500 prepaid before Nov 1** — 3.3–4.1 months of the nut before the first flake; per-push overflow ≈ \$6,600 more on a normal year (n=0). **Buy:** two-stage walk-behind blowers (Ariens Deluxe 28 ≈ \$1,549), markers, plastic shovels, a push spreader — blower #1 on the first 10 contracts, #2 only after #15. **Never a plow on the Denali:** a half-ton install is ≈\$4,000–\$4,500, GM warns against plowing without the plow-prep package, plow damage is not warranty-covered, and the truck is the W-2 commuter. **Insurance is the load-bearing check:** many GL policies carry a snow-and-ice-operations exclusion; get the agent's written yes on residential snow before Oct 20 or bind a residential snow endorsement. Contract language: we clear, we don't promise bare pavement; ice-melt is an opt-in add-on; no commercial lots. **Tax:** snow removal is sales-tax-free in ND and MN; ice-melt *application* is taxable in MN, so keep it off EGF contracts or tax that line only. **Site:** a snow-removal service with sizes drive / drive-walk / corner, the seasonal contract on the existing Stripe-plan pattern, ?s=snow; the owner board's same-street clusters are the snow routes.

Line B — Winter haul, no code

The pricebook already prices it (\$59 one piece → \$365 two trips) and sits under every comparable: 1-800-GOT-JUNK serves GF

Line C — Spring power-rake, summer pressure washing (2027)

from Fargo at \$400–\$600 a half load, LoadUp from \$79 a single item, the city's special pickup is \$48 minimum + \$1 a minute, curbside only — **we carry from the basement, which is the whole difference.** Landfill \$23 minimum, \$59.54 a ton. Appliances stay a quarter load (\$85–\$130) with the refrigerant add-on; scrap is a \$15–\$35 rebate on the dump ticket, not a revenue line — "MinnKota pays" is unverified and stays out of the copy (the GF scrap buyers are Spicer and Residual Materials). Marketplace delivery prices at the single-item rung (\$59–\$95) — "we bring it in, not out". **The calendar that matters:** UND fall finals Dec 14–18, spring finals May 10–14, halls close May 14 at 7 pm; 235 UND-listed off-campus rentals. The landlord packs already exist — this is two emails to the four named property managers, Nov 20 and Apr 15. **Sizing:** 4–8 jobs a month × \$168–\$213 kept = **\$670–\$1,700 a month Dec–Mar** (n=0). Not a season-maker; it keeps the GBP alive and pays the fuel. Permit \$13-0406.1 before the first winter haul; MN SWM 9.75% on EGF junk.

Power-rake (Apr 16 – May 31): dethatching runs \$146–\$246 nationally, \$10–\$30 per 1,000 sf — **\$75–\$225 on the standard lot**, sold as an add-on on the plan's spring visit and billed at the visit like the gutter add-on. Rent the dethatcher the first spring; buy only if more than 15 add-ons sell. **Pressure washing** (Jun–Aug, the second dead window): driveway \$175–\$320 for a 576-sf slab, siding \$0.20–\$0.50/sf with a \$150–\$250 minimum. Test bundle: **driveway + front walk + city sidewalk \$175–\$250; single-story siding from the ground +\$250–\$400.** Ground-level siding with a wand fits the no-ladder brand the way the gutter vacuum does — no two-story, ever. Rig \$1,500–\$2,500 bought in April 2027 from summer cash. Sizing: 40 jobs × \$175–\$320 = **\$7,000–\$12,800** (n=0). **MN:** exterior building cleaning is likely taxable "building cleaning and maintenance" in Minnesota — confirm with the CPA before quoting siding in EGF. Site: a pressure-washing key with sizes drive / drive-walks / siding-ranch.

Launch calendar and gates

Date	Action	Buy	Price to test	First-dollar gate
Sept 17–20	Hangers go out with the fall promo; add one line: "Ask about the winter plan."	—	—	—
Sept 25	Agent letter: the GL quote must cover residential snow & ice; bind by Oct 20. Read the warranty contract for commercial-use / plow language.	GL ≈\$85/mo	—	Blocker for Line A
Oct 1	Winter text to the 65 households + GBP post; Stripe link live	—	\$450–\$550 season / \$40–\$50 push	10 prepaid by Oct 15
Oct 5 – Nov 8	Every done text carries the SNOW line (below)	—	—	—
Oct 15	Blower #1 on the first 10 contracts; driveway markers	≈\$1,549	—	Under 10 → hold the blower
Oct 25	Decision: ≥20 contracts → blower #2 + the brother's winter hours; 12–19 → one crew, cap 20; under 12 → per-push only	≈\$1,549	—	—
Nov 1	Season starts. Hauler permit filed for the winter haul.	\$75 + bond	—	—
Nov 20	PM email #1 for the Dec 14–18 UND turns (landlord packs)	—	pricebook	1 PM booking by Dec 12
Feb 15, 2027	PM retainer pitch with a winter of references	—	unknown (n=0)	—
Apr 1	Spring-visit reminder with the power-rake add-on; rent the dethatcher	rental	\$75–\$225	—
Apr 15	PM email #2 for the May 10–14 turns	—	pricebook	—
Apr 20	Buy the pressure-washing rig	\$1,500–\$2,500	—	—
Jun 1	Pressure-washing launch to the list + GBP	—	\$175–\$250 drive / +\$250–\$400 siding	5 jobs by Jun 21

Selling it at the point of the fall job — one offer per touch, no price stacking

- **Done text, Oct–Nov, after the review ask:** "One more thing — we're doing snow this winter for the houses we already know: driveway, city sidewalk and your steps, every snowfall over an inch, inside the city's 24-hour rule. Prepaid season or per push. Reply SNOW and I'll send the link."
- **Two-visit plan buyers:** "Your spring visit is locked. If you want the sidewalk kept legal between now and then, the winter plan is separate and covers Nov 1–Apr 1. Reply SNOW for the link — same crew, same street."
- **Winter-plan confirmation (Stripe → a bookedEmail variant):** "Season locked: driveway + sidewalk + steps, every 1-inch snowfall, Nov 1–Apr 1. We clear the berm after the city plow too. Nothing to call in — we watch the gauge."

- **Spring done text (May):** "Yard's clean. In June we bring the pressure washer — driveway, walks, and the siding from the ground. Reply WASH and you're first on the street."
- **Neighbor mechanism:** when a snow contract lands, the board's same-street cluster shows which fall customers on that block haven't replied; one manual text ("your neighbor at ___ is on the winter plan — same day, same crew") is the cheapest acquisition on the board. The block credit does not apply to plans; the route logic does.
- **Re-price after year one** from measured minutes per stop $\times$ loaded crew rate + fuel, $\times$ 14.7 events $\times$ 1.35. If that lands outside \$350–\$600 the stop is mis-sized, not the price.

C. The tax playbook — verified, with the CPA questions marked

Single-member LLC, disregarded → Schedule C on the same 1040 as the \$55k W-2. Fourteen load-bearing facts were checked against the IRS, the Century Code and the MN Department of Revenue; thirteen held, one (the home office) needed a nuance, noted below. Nothing here is investment advice; the last column is what to hand the CPA.

Question	Answer	Rule / trigger
Real marginal rate on a dollar of job profit (2026, single, \$55k W-2)	23.1% — 14.13¢ SE tax + 8.92¢ federal; ND \$0	Holds until federal taxable income crosses \$50,400 single; then ≈32% (30.5¢ + ND 1.45¢). With only the W-2 that crossing is ≈\$15,500 of business net; with trading gains on top it comes sooner (\$E)
Is 25% of collected the right set-aside?	Yes — keep it	On job revenue alone 18% would do; the portfolio stacks into the 22% bracket. True-up Dec 1 (\$D)
The \$1,862 Milwaukee kit	Expense in full in 2026 — de minimis safe harbor , every item under \$2,500 per invoice	Attach the \$1.263(a)-1(f) election statement to the return — every year, covering every qualifying purchase that year. The receipt scanner keeps the invoices
The shed (~\$2,277)	De minimis too if the invoice, delivery included, is ≤ \$2,500 ; otherwise 100% bonus (Form 4562), same result	Ask for delivery on a separate invoice before ordering. A free-standing shed holding only business gear is also a "separate structure" — no principal-place test needed
The truck, 2026	Standard mileage (72.5¢ Jan–Jun / 76¢ Jul–Dec) plus the business share of the 10% loan interest and business parking/tolls on Schedule C	Year-one choice keeps both doors open; actual-with-bonus in year one would have closed the mileage door for the truck's life. Business use will be well under 50% (it is the W-2 commuter) so \$179/bonus on the truck was never available anyway. Re-run actual vs mileage on Jan 1, 2027: if 2026 total miles are under ≈17,500 and running costs ≈\$13k , actual (straight-line) wins for 2027
What is <i>not</i> deductible on top of mileage	The \$550 payment, the \$220 warranty, the \$75 insurance, fuel, tires	Books fix: they stay in the monthly nut as cash obligations — never booked as Schedule C expenses while on the mileage method (the classic double-dip)
Home office	Open one now — the biggest untaken lever	A room or walled-off corner used <i>exclusively and regularly</i> for admin (board, quotes, books, crew pay) with no other fixed admin location qualifies as the principal place of business; then every home→job leg is business mileage instead of commuting. Simplified \$5/sq ft up to 300 sq ft — the nuance: capped at the business's gross income less its other expenses, and the unused amount does not carry forward. Photograph it, note the square feet in Setup
The brother	Fully taxable W-2 — no sibling exemption federally (§3121(b)(3)) covers a child under 18 of a parent, a spouse, a parent — never a sibling), at WSI, or at Job Service ND	Under the LLC's own EIN (a disregarded LLC is a separate entity for employment taxes). $\approx 240 \text{ h} \times \$19 = \$4,560 + \text{FICA } \$349 + \text{FUTA } \$27 + \text{ND UI } \approx \$46 + \text{WSI } (\$250 \text{ minimum}) \approx \mathbf{\$5,250}$, all deductible on line 26 via "Record pay". Pay every 2026 hour by Dec 31 — cash basis; never "cash now, W-2 later": an uninsured injury is personal liability
Retirement plan	Solo 401(k), Roth deferrals while in the 12% bracket	2026 deferral limit \$24,500 (shared with any W-2 plan); employer side $\approx 20\%$ of net. A pre-tax deferral saves only $\approx 9.6\%$ per \$1 here ($12\% \times 0.8$ — QBI shrinks) and never touches SE tax. Keep the brother under 500 hours a plan year or he earns the right to defer from 2028 (no cost to you). Not a SEP: from his third season it would owe him whatever % you give yourself. Adopt and defer by Apr 15, 2027 for 2026. The CPA sizes it; this is mechanics, not advice
S-corp	Not yet	Saves $\approx 14\%$ of (net – reasonable salary) minus \$2,000–\$4,000 of payroll and 1120-S cost; break-even $\approx \$60\text{--}80\text{k}$ net. File Form 2553 in the January after the first calendar year that clears $\sim \$60\text{k}$
\$195 start-up costs	Up to \$5,000 in the first active year	LLC filing, the domain and web stack before the first booking, hanger design and print, GBP set-up. Not equipment (that is the de minimis row) and nothing after the site could take a booking. Check <code>business.startDate</code> in Setup = the day the site could take a booking, not the LLC filing date
QBI (§199A)	Permanent, 20%; a \$400 floor exists but the regular 20% beats it above \$2,150 of net	Reduced by the half-SE deduction and by pre-tax retirement contributions — which is why Roth wins in a 12% year

Question	Answer	Rule / trigger
ND	0% to \$48,475 taxable (2025 schedule; 2026 indexes higher, unpublished), then 1.95%	No franchise tax; the only recurring charge is the \$50 annual report by Nov 15 — first one Nov 15, 2027 for an LLC formed in 2026; \$50 late fee

The mechanism, per dollar of job profit

SE tax takes **14.13¢** ($15.3\% \times 92.35\%$). Half of that, 7.07¢, is deducted above the line; QBI removes 20% of what is left, 18.59¢; so only **74.3¢** of each dollar reaches the income-tax brackets. At 12% that is 8.92¢ → **23.05¢ total**. At 22% it is 16.36¢, plus ND at $1.95\% \times 0.743 = 1.45\text{¢} \rightarrow \approx 32\text{¢}$. That nine-point step is why timing matters: a deduction taken in a 12% year is worth ~23¢, the same deduction in a 22% year ~32¢. **Rule:** equipment that earns fall revenue is bought now; discretionary equipment and the shed wait for January 2027 if 2027 looks like a 22% year ($n=0$).

How the streams stack on one 1040 — 2026 tables, single filer

Case	Side income	Taxable	SE	Federal	ND	Total	Cost of the side income	Next \$1k job	Next \$1k trade
W-2 only — the baseline	\$0	\$38,900	\$0	\$4,420	\$0	\$4,420	\$0	23%	12%
+ Pick It Up E \$7,500 net (W-2 kept, ≈50 jobs)	\$7,500	\$44,476	\$1,060	\$5,089	\$0	\$6,149	\$1,729	23%	12%
+ Pick It Up E \$12,000 net (leave from Oct 5, ≈84 jobs)	\$12,000	\$47,822	\$1,696	\$5,491	\$0	\$7,186	\$2,766	23%	13%
+ LuxeForge –\$2,000, trading +\$10,000 realized	\$20,000	\$56,335	\$1,413	\$7,106	\$153	\$8,672	\$4,252	32%	24%
+ trading at the \$1,000/wk target for six months (+\$26,000)	\$36,000	\$72,335	\$1,413	\$10,626	\$465	\$12,504	\$8,084	32%	24%
+ a full year at target (+\$52,000) and a rental netting \$3,000	\$65,000	\$101,335	\$1,413	\$17,006	\$1,031	\$19,449	\$15,029	32%	24%

Computed by `stack()` in `scripts/plan-model.mjs` from the 2026 IRS figures (standard deduction \$16,100; 10% to \$12,400, 12% to \$50,400, 22% to \$105,700) and ND's 2025 schedule (0% to \$48,475, then 1.95%; 2026 indexes higher). "Schedule C" nets Pick It Up E and LuxeForge; trading gains are short-term (ordinary rates), filed as an investor; rent is Schedule E without the QBI safe harbor. Married filing jointly with no spouse income keeps every row in the 12% bracket (it runs to \$100,800) — filing status is the single biggest unknown on this page. The last two columns are the tax on the *next* thousand dollars of each kind of income — the number the reserve has to match.

Every deduction, ranked by what it is worth to you

- 1. Mileage, by leg, at the IRS rate** — the app's log already stamps 72.5¢ / 76¢ per trip. Also photograph the odometer on Jan 1 and Dec 31: business % needs the denominator. Add the business share of the loan interest (≈\$2,600 of interest in the next 12 months; at 20% business use ≈\$520, at 60% ≈\$1,560).
- 2. The home office** — worth \$500 on its own at 100 sq ft, but it flips every home→job leg (≈85 jobs × 12 mi + 30 dump runs) from commuting into business miles. Effective the day the space becomes exclusive.
- 3. The brother's wages and the employer taxes on them** (line 26), WSI, the payroll app.
- 4. De minimis expensing** of the kit and, if invoiced right, the shed; 100% bonus for anything over \$2,500 that isn't the truck.
- 5. \$195 start-up costs**, up to \$5,000, on the 2026 return.
- 6. Everything the business pays that isn't the truck:** GL, the hauler permit and bond, Supabase/Netlify/domain/Twilio, Stripe fees, the business share of the cell phone, hangers, bags, dump tickets, bank fees, the CPA.
- 7. The 12-month rule** — a 12-month GL policy paid in December 2026 that starts by Dec 31 is deductible in 2026; one that starts in February 2027 is not. A cash-flow tool more than a tax tool.
- 8. Solo 401(k) Roth deferrals** — no deduction today, tax-free growth; flip to pre-tax in a 22% year (17.6¢ per \$1). The CPA sizes the number.

Minnesota — every East Grand Forks job

Leaf raking is a taxable lawn service in MN (the bill that would have removed it, HF4331, died in committee May 18, 2026) — **8.375%** combined on leaf and gutter work; junk hauling from an EGF residence carries the **Solid Waste Management tax, 9.75%** residential, collected by the hauler; both need the MN Tax ID first. Reciprocity with ND covers **wages only** — EGF Schedule C profit is Minnesota-source, so a nonresident MN return (M1NR) joins the pile and ND credits the MN tax. Snow is tax-free on both sides; ice-melt application is taxable in MN; pressure washing is unverified. **Decision rule:** if EGF is under ~10% of jobs, price EGF work ~10% higher to carry the registrations and the extra return, or decline EGF junk hauls until the volume justifies the SWM registration ($n=0$ on the 10%).

Records that survive an audit

Item	Standard	Covered by
Mileage	Contemporaneous, per leg, purpose, at or near the time	The app; plus Jan 1 / Dec 31 odometer photos
Receipts	Vendor, date, amount, purpose; ≥\$75 needs the receipt	Receipt scanner, sha256-deduped, phase-tagged
Payroll	941s (or 944), W-2/W-3 by Jan 31, ND withholding, Job Service quarterly, WSI annual, I-9, new-hire report	Payroll app + the crew punches
Home office	Photo, sq ft, date exclusive use began	Add a Setup field
De minimis election	Statement on every year's return	CPA checklist
Truck basis	Cumulative business miles × the depreciation-per-mile table (35¢ in 2026)	CSV export → CPA at sale

Deadlines

Date	What
Before the brother's first shift	EIN → WSI → Job Service ND → new-hire report → I-9 / W-4
Oct 1	Withholding check: pay-stub YTD federal × 12/9 vs 2025 Form 1040 line 24
Oct 31	Q3 941 if any Q3 wages
Dec 1	Set-aside true-up; W-4 line 4(c) if withholding is short (\$E)
Dec 31	Equipment placed in service; brother paid in full; 12-month prepaids; odometer photo
Jan 15, 2027	Q4 estimate — only if withholding doesn't cover 2025's tax
Jan 31, 2027	W-2/W-3, Q4 941, Form 940, Job Service Q4, ND withholding annual
Apr 15, 2027	1040 + Schedule C / SE / D + Form 8995 (QBI) + de minimis statement; ND-1; MN M1NR if any EGF work; last day to adopt a Solo 401(k) for 2026
Nov 15, 2027	First ND LLC annual report, \$50
Jan 2028	Form 2553 only if 2027 net cleared ~\$60k

D. Where the revenue goes — the waterfall

#	Bucket	Rule	Account
0	MN sales / SWM tax (EGF jobs only)	Collected on top of the price, 100% pass-through, remitted on the MN schedule. Never yours. No EGF job before the MN Tax ID	"MN tax" sub-account
1	Tax reserve, 25% of every dollar collected	Moves the day Stripe pays out; cash, check and Venmo the day they're logged. Two lines inside the account: Pick It Up E / trading	Tax savings
2	Job variable costs	Dump ≈\$15, bags \$4, Stripe ≈\$5, the brother's hours + 9.25% burden when he's on the truck (≈\$45 a job). WSI's \$250 minimum before his first shift	Operating
3	The nut, \$1,013 on the 1st	Truck \$550, warranty \$220, auto \$75, web \$48, GL \$85, Twilio \$5, phone \$30. The three truck items are personal bills the business pays — owner draws on the books, tagged that way in Setup	Operating → personal
4	Winter escrow	100% of what is left until \$5,065 (November plus Dec–Mar × \$1,013). Fills in October in the realistic case. Draws \$1,013 on the 1st Dec–Mar. Refill target after spring: \$3,039 for June–August	Escrow savings
5	Repair reserve	\$1,000, fills right after the escrow. Blower, vacuum, tarp failures; truck repairs live inside the mileage rate but the cash still has to exist. Refill whenever drawn	Same savings, tagged
6	Owner draw	Everything above the floor, once a month on the 2nd. Floor = tax reserve + escrow target + \$1,000 repair + one month's nut in operating. Draws, never salary — no W-2 to yourself, no payroll; tax is on profit whether or not you draw	Personal

The set-aside: 25% stays. Two builders disagreed — here is the resolution

Tax is owed on *profit*; the app reserves a share of *collected*. On job revenue alone the right share is the marginal rate × the net margin: 23% × ≈61% ≈ 14%, so **18%** is a comfortable reserve and 25% over-holds by ≈\$2,400 on the realistic 2026 case — that was the cash builder's argument, and it is correct *for this business in isolation*. It is wrong for the portfolio: \$10k of realized trading gains in the same year pushes the single filer into the 22% bracket, the marginal rate on every job dollar becomes 32%, and the same collections then need ≈20–24% — with prepaid plans and gift cards at 100% margin needing the full 32%. Trading gains have no withholding at all. **So: 25% of collected stays the rule in the app**; the cost of over-reserving is only timing (it comes back at filing in April), the cost of under-reserving is a bill with no cash behind it. **True-up on Dec 1**: compute YTD Schedule C net × the marginal rate from the table above, add the marginal rate × YTD realized trading gains, compare to the tax account; release any clear surplus to the escrow, or top up. Married filing jointly with no spouse income would put 18% back on the table — the CPA answers that one.

The truck loan — \$26,000 at 10%, \$550 a month

Extra principal a month	Months to payoff	Total interest	Interest saved	Months cut
\$0 — as is	61	\$7,189	—	—
+\$100	49	\$5,758	\$1,431	12
+\$200	42	\$4,811	\$2,378	19
+\$400	32	\$3,634	\$3,556	29

Standard amortization; first payment is \$217 of interest and \$333 of principal. Only the business-use share of the interest is deductible, so prepaying returns 8.5–10% after tax, guaranteed — more than any savings account and with no market risk. Extra principal comes **only from bucket 6**, never from the escrow or the tax account, and only after debt above 10% (there is none today) is gone.

Equipment — the 1.5× hurdle

Buy a tool only if (extra jobs it enables × \$213 kept solo / \$168 with the helper) ≥ **1.5 × its price inside the season it is first used**. Anything slower loses to the 10% loan.

Item	Price (n=0)	Extra jobs needed	Verdict
Second M18 blower	≈\$350	3 solo / 4 helper	Yes if the brother is on the truck — a second blower line pays back in a week of October
Snow blower #1 / #2	≈\$1,549 each	≈6 prepaid contracts or ≈60 pushes each	Only on the Oct 15 / Oct 25 gates in \$B — 10 prepaid contracts buy #1, 20 buy #2
Dump trailer	≈\$6,000	43 solo / 54 helper — half the fall	No in 2026 . Junk is 20% of the mix; buy when the board shows bed-limited jobs turned away — and never for work across the river
Pressure-washing rig	\$1,500–\$2,500	11–19 jobs in one summer	April 2027, from summer cash

Unspent equipment budget: \$5,000 – \$1,862 = \$3,138. Spend the blower; the rest doubles as the repair reserve until October fills it.

Fixed costs in the dead months — what can move, what can't

Cost	Move	Saves Dec–Mar	What breaks
Truck \$550	Nothing but extra principal	—	—
Extended warranty \$220	Unknown whether it cancels pro-rata — read the clause this week. \$2,640 a year on a 2020 truck is a real question for the CPA and the dealer, not a "pause"	\$0–\$880	Nothing — the only fixed cost with a possible winter cut nobody has checked
Auto \$75	Cannot — ND requires continuous coverage and it's the commuter. The bigger issue is the other way: personal Progressive excludes for-pay hauling; commercial auto is an <i>increase</i> , quote it	\$0	—
Supabase Pro \$25	Keep. The free tier pauses after 7 idle days and a paused database fails bookings and Stripe silently while the home page still renders — it happened once already. Winter is exactly when plan and gift-card sales land	\$0	Bookings, if cut
Netlify	Drop to Free only if Sept–Nov usage is under ~200 credits a month on the usage page (300-credit hard cap; overage pauses the site)	\$0–\$36	The site, if the cap trips
Twilio ≈\$5	Keep the number; winter usage ≈ \$0. Releasing it means re-verification in spring	≈\$10	The line
GL \$85	Cancels any time pro-rata — but the hauler permit requires proof of GL and a lapse may void it; every winter haul would be uninsured; April is new underwriting. Rule: cancel Dec 1 only if the board has zero Dec–Mar jobs and GF Finance (701-746-2664) confirms in writing the permit survives a lapse. If snow launches, GL stays	\$0–\$340	The permit

Floor if every safe cut lands: ≈\$917 a month. Plan the escrow on \$1,013 and treat the cuts as upside.

Surplus — what to do with a dollar nothing above needs, best return first

- Equipment that clears the 1.5× hurdle** — the second M18 blower, and in 2026 nothing else on the list.
- Spring marketing with a proven cost per job:** the ?s=dh tag on /jobs gives jobs-per-hanger by Nov 8. Under \$30 a job (a seventh of a \$213 contribution) → reprint 500 for April 1, a 7:1 return that beats everything below. Unknown or over \$60 → don't.
- Extra principal on the 10% truck loan** — 8.5–10% after tax, guaranteed; \$200 a month saves \$2,378 and 19 months. Before any retirement account while the rate is 10%.
- Solo 401(k) / IRA** — a tax mechanism the CPA sizes, not a recommendation to invest: weak at a 12% bracket, does nothing to SE tax, strongest as Roth this year.

5. **A dump trailer** only when the board shows bed-limited jobs turned away; never from the escrow.

The cash calendar, Sept 2026 → May 2027 — realistic case, 25% reserve

Month	Jobs	Collected	Variable	Tax 25%	Nut	One-time	Escrow ±	Escrow bal.	Repair	Owner draw	Note
Sep 26	8	\$3,470	\$449	\$868	\$1,013	\$988	\$153	\$153	\$0	—	hangers, permit, GL, WSI, blower
Oct 26	46	\$11,126	\$2,580	\$2,782	\$1,013	—	\$4,752	\$4,904	\$0	—	
Nov 26	26	\$7,902	\$1,458	\$1,976	\$1,013	—	\$161	\$5,065	\$1,000	\$2,295	10 plans prepaid, \$2,800
Dec 26	4	\$1,780	\$224	\$445	\$1,013	—	—	\$5,065	\$1,000	\$98	UND turns + 5 gift cards
Jan 27	0	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$1,013	—	−\$1,013	\$4,052	\$1,000	—	
Feb 27	0	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$1,013	—	−\$1,013	\$3,039	\$1,000	—	
Mar 27	0	\$1,000	\$0	\$250	\$1,013	—	−\$263	\$2,776	\$1,000	—	20 spring deposits
Apr 27	12	\$2,508	\$673	\$627	\$1,013	—	\$195	\$2,971	\$1,000	—	
May 27	28	\$4,852	\$1,571	\$1,213	\$1,013	—	\$1,055	\$4,026	\$1,000	—	
Total	124	\$32,638	\$6,955	\$8,160	\$9,117	\$988				\$2,393	

80 fall jobs and 40 spring at the pricebook's blended ticket, plus \$1,500 of early deposits, 10 two-visit plans (\$2,800) in November, five gift cards and the UND turns in December, 20 spring deposits in March; helper on half the fall jobs. Reading it: the escrow is full on **Oct 31**, never drops below **\$2,776**, and spring refills it to **\$4,026** by May 31 — enough for June–August with change toward next winter. Owner cash draws are **\$2,393** Sept–Dec *plus* the business covering ≈\$3,380 of your personal truck, warranty and auto bills over the same four months. The tax account holds on Dec 31 against a Pick It Up E bill of ≈\$3,650 with nothing else on the return — the difference is the cushion for the trading account's tax, or it comes back in April. At 18% the draw would be and the account — the same money, earlier. If the fall comes in at the keep-the-W-2 case (40–55 jobs) the escrow still fills, in November instead of October, and the owner draw is ≈\$0 until spring. Every job count is n=0; re-run cashCalendar() with real Books numbers on Nov 8 and Mar 1.

E. The portfolio — four streams, three tax regimes, one return

Stream	Entity	Where it lands	SE tax?	QBI?	Election / deadline	Money kept in
Pick It Up E	Pick It Up E LLC (ND, filed Sept 11), single-member, disregarded	Schedule C + SE; W-2/941/940 for the brother under the LLC's EIN	Yes	Yes	ND annual report \$50 by Nov 15 (first 2027); no S-corp; de minimis statement yearly	LLC checking + its own Stripe account
luxeforge.io	Today a sole proprietorship at ≈\$0 revenue. Form LuxeForge LLC (\$135) the day a subscriber can enter a card or a Terms of Service names a party	A second, separate Schedule C — one per business; a loss nets against Pick It Up E's positive QBI	Yes once profitable	Yes — software subscriptions are not a specified service business	\$195: first \$5,000 of pre-launch cost in the launch year; watch the hobby-loss presumption (profit 3 of 5 years)	The existing "LuxeForge" Stripe account, LLC checking when formed
Day trading	No entity. Personal brokerage account, filed as an investor	Form 8949 → Schedule D	No — gains on securities are excluded	No — capital gains are excluded, and "trading" is a specified service anyway	\$475(f) for 2026 closed Apr 15, 2026 ; for 2027 the statement rides on the 2026 return or extension by Apr 15, 2027 , Form 3115 with the 2027 return. Wash sales (\$1091, 30 days either side, across accounts and IRAs); net losses capped at \$3,000 a year, carried forward	The brokerage account only — never a business deposit in, never a business bill out
Rental real estate (future)	Title in your own name + landlord (DP-3) policy + \$1M umbrella. Move to an ND LLC when equity exceeds the umbrella, a second property lands, or a lender closes in-entity — with Fannie Mae's D1-4.1-02 consent check first (Garn-St Germain protects trusts, not LLCs)	Schedule E; 27.5-year depreciation; Form 8582	No	Only if it is a real business or logs 250+ hours a year under the Rev. Proc. 2019-38 safe harbor with its own books	\$25,000 active-participation loss allowance against the W-2, phased out \$100–150k MAGI — fully available here; the safe-harbor statement each year it's used	One operating account per property; security deposits per ND landlord-tenant law

Stream	Entity	Where it lands	SE tax?	QBI?	Election / deadline	Money kept in
The W-2 (\$55k)	—	1040 line 1	FICA withheld	No	W-4 line 4(c) is the penalty shield (below)	Personal checking — the only hub; money crosses only as a dated owner contribution or draw, logged in the app

This week: split the Stripe account from LuxeForge

Today the \$50 deposits settle into a Stripe account whose legal entity, tax ID and public name are LuxeForge. Three concrete problems: **commingling** — one Stripe account pays one bank, so the truck business's revenue lands in the SaaS's cash, and commingled accounts are a named alter-ego factor in North Dakota veil-piercing cases (*Jablonsky v. Klemm*, 1985); **1099-K** — Stripe reports each account's gross under that account's TIN (the 2026 threshold is back to \$20,000 and 200 transactions — you may stay under it, the misattribution still matters if you cross); and **chargebacks** — a Grand Forks homeowner who sees "LUXEFORGE" on a card statement is an unrecognized-charge dispute waiting to happen. **Mechanics, same login, ~30 minutes:** Stripe dashboard → account picker → **New account** → legal entity Pick It Up E LLC, its EIN, its bank, public name "Pick It Up E", statement descriptor PICKITUPE, support phone 701-213-3969 → recreate the three two-visit-plan products as yearly prices (\$180 / \$280 / \$460) → add the webhook endpoint for /api/stripe/webhook → replace the five Stripe variables in Netlify: STRIPE_SECRET_KEY, STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET, STRIPE_PRICE_SMALL / _STANDARD / _LARGE (you paste them, per the standing rule) → test one \$50 deposit and one plan checkout end to end. Deposits already collected: transfer the Pick It Up E portion to the LLC bank with a memo and record it in the app as a prior-period inflow. The old account stays LuxeForge-only; when LuxeForge LLC exists, update that account's legal entity — don't open a third. Needs the EIN, so it lands the day the LLC shows active.

Trading — the mechanics that matter, no advice on what to trade

Trader tax status needs all three of: profit sought from daily price movements, *substantial* activity, and continuity and regularity — facts and circumstances, no bright-line trade count. The Tax Court has denied it at 200–535 trades a year when trades fell on fewer than half of the trading days, with multi-week gaps, or with holding periods of weeks (*Holsinger* 2008, *Endicott* 2013, *Nelson* 2013 — and in *Nelson* the taxpayer also had a W-2 job). A full-time job is a strong negative on "time devoted". **Treat yourself as an investor unless the CPA says otherwise after a full year of day-by-day records** — hours and fills, starting now, are the only evidence that would ever change that. Investor consequences: short-term gains at ordinary rates (12% or 22% here, plus ND above the 0% band); long-term at 0% up to \$49,450 of taxable income then 15%; net losses capped at **\$3,000 a year** against other income, carried forward indefinitely; the **wash-sale rule** disallows a loss when substantially identical stock is bought within 30 days either side — including in an IRA, and across accounts, which the broker's 1099-B does not track for you; platform and data costs are not deductible for an investor. **\$475(f) mark-to-market** (ordinary gains and losses on Form 4797, no wash sales, no \$3,000 cap) exists only for a trader; for 2026 the election window closed on April 15, 2026 and late elections are essentially never allowed; for 2027 the statement attaches to the 2026 return or extension by April 15, 2027, with Form 3115 on the 2027 return. A "trading LLC" does not create trader status — it only changes election timing and adds a return — so there is none. **Reserve:** sweep the marginal rate (12%, 22% above the line) of each month's realized net gain into the tax account's "trading" line; there is no withholding on gains. **Never use trading capital as working capital:** withdrawing means selling (gains taxed now, losses capped), margin makes a withdrawal a forced liquidation, business bills are dated and markets aren't, and a margin account under FINRA's \$25,000 pattern-day-trader minimum loses the ability to day trade (a 2025 amendment to that rule was pending — status unknown). The brokerage account never receives a business deposit and never pays a business bill.

Rental, S-corp, holding company — the standing decisions, with their triggers

- **Rental:** Schedule E, no SE tax; a loss offsets the W-2 up to \$25,000 a year if you actively participate (approve tenants, set rent) — fully available at this income. QBI on rent needs the 250-hour safe harbor and its own books, or a real \$162 business. Conventional loans close in a person's name; Fannie Mae allows a later deed into an LLC you control without triggering the due-on-sale clause, but the LLC has to deed it back to refinance; any other lender needs written consent. ND LLC \$135 + \$50 a year; no ND transfer tax; county recording fee and the umbrella premium are unknown — quote them. NIIT (3.8%) starts at \$200k of income — not binding.
- **S-corp:** SE tax on \$7,500 of net is ≈\$1,060; payroll and an 1120-S cost more than that. Revisit when combined Schedule C net is over ~\$50–60k two years running and projected SE savings exceed ~\$3k a year after a reasonable salary. Note an S-corp adds WSI and unemployment on your own wages in ND, which a Schedule C owner never pays.
- **Holding company:** no. ND taxes residents on all income wherever earned; a Wyoming LLC doing business in ND registers as a foreign LLC and pays ND fees anyway — one more return, one more registered agent, no tax saved. Revisit when two operating entities each hold meaningful equity (rule of thumb > \$50k each) or a second rental LLC exists. Outside money into LuxeForge would mean a Delaware C-corp for the SaaS alone, not a holdco.
- **BOI / FinCEN:** nothing to file — domestic LLCs were exempted in March 2025.

Estimated taxes with a W-2 — the penalty-proofing is nearly free

No penalty if you owe under \$1,000 after withholding, or paid in 90% of this year's tax, or **100% of last year's** (110% if prior AGI was over \$150k). **Withholding counts as paid evenly through the year**, so a December W-4 top-up cures the whole year; a December 1040-ES payment does not. **2026:** 2025 was W-2-only, so if the job and the W-4 are unchanged, 2026 withholding $\approx$ 2025's total tax and the prior-year harbor is met automatically — the side-income bill is simply paid by April 15, 2027, no penalty. Verify Oct 1: pay-stub YTD federal withholding $\times$ 12/9 against 2025 Form 1040 line 24; if short, add the gap $\div$ remaining paychecks to W-4 line 4(c). **2027:** prior-year tax now includes the side income, so set line 4(c) in January to $(2026 \text{ total tax} - \text{expected 2027 base withholding}) \div 26$ — that replaces 1040-ES entirely for a W-2 earner. Use 1040-ES only if one trading month realizes more than the reserve can absorb (Sept 15 and Jan 15). The 25% sweep on Pick It Up E is the bill; the withholding is the shield; the two are different jobs.

Dated to-do list across the portfolio

Date	Action
Day the LLC shows active (~Sept 18)	EIN (CP-575 on file) → LLC checking → tax-savings account with two ledger lines (Pick It Up E / trading) → escrow sub-account → new Stripe account and Netlify key swap → WSI → Job Service ND → new-hire report, W-4, I-9 before the brother's first shift
Sept 25	GL agent letter (snow & ice cover in writing); read the warranty's cancellation and commercial-use clauses; commercial-auto quote from Progressive
Oct 1	Withholding check vs 2025 line 24; winter text to the 65 households; start the trading reserve sweep; home office made exclusive, photographed, square feet in Setup
Oct 15	Truck method confirmed with the CPA (standard mileage, interest share) — binding for the vehicle's life; blower #1 gate
Nov 8	Season close: re-run the cash calendar with real Books numbers; cost per job by channel; equipment hurdle re-check
Dec 1	Set-aside true-up; W-4 line 4(c) if short; GL keep/cancel decision on the two conditions; escrow $\geq$ \$5,065 or no December draw
Dec 15	\$195 list for LuxeForge dated and totaled; trading fill export for wash-sale review; TTS question to the CPA (almost certainly no — if yes, the \$475(f) statement rides on the 2026 return)
Dec 31	Brother paid in full; equipment in service; odometer photo; any 12-month prepaid that starts by Dec 31
Jan 2027	W-4 line 4(c) for 2027; Solo 401(k) opened if the CPA sizes it; Jan 31 payroll filings
Mar 1	Spring booking opens (\$50 deposits are the thinnest month's cash); re-run the calendar
Apr 15, 2027	1040 with two Schedule Cs, SE, D/8949, 8995, the de minimis statement; ND-1; M1NR if any EGF job; \$475(f) deadline for 2027; Solo 401(k) deferral deadline for 2026
On trigger	LuxeForge LLC the day a subscriber can pay · rental LLC on equity / second property / in-entity lender · S-corp after two ~\$60k years · holdco after two operating entities each > ~\$50k equity

Unknown, not guessed: ND's 2026 indexed bracket thresholds; Job Service ND's first-year employer rate (1% new-employer rate reported; confirm); the Grand Forks County deed-recording fee; umbrella and landlord-policy premiums; whether the warranty cancels pro-rata; the 2026 city sidewalk-clearing fee per foot; whether the GL quote excludes snow; MN taxability of pressure washing; filing status (every rate above assumes single); the 2025 Form 1040 line 24 figure the safe-harbor check needs — pull it from the filed return.

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The 13-week calendar

Week	Actions	Owner hours (desk + truck)	Leads / jobs (n=0)
1 · Sept 14–20	Bind GL; hauler permit + door-hanger ruling; fix REVIEW_URL; GBP complete; six citations; on-page fixes; hangers arrive Sept 17; promo extended to Oct 10; EIN when the SOS shows active	14 + 10	5–8 / 2–3 (rake-to-curb and out-of-city until the permit issues)
2 · Sept 21–27	Ship /leaf-cleanup-grand-forks and /junk-removal-grand-forks, request indexing; hang the first 500 (if cleared); order a second 500; apply for LSA; MN Tax ID; Progressive quote; two PM calls; join the Facebook groups	10 + 12	6–8 / 3–4
3 · Sept 28–Oct 4	Ship /gutter-cleaning-grand-forks and /east-grand-forks; first review asks, staggered; Google Ads live Oct 1 at \$15/day on leaf terms; Nextdoor boost in the four zones; hang the second 500 Oct 2–3 ("before the city vacuum"); first freeze ~Sept 28; PTO decision by Oct 1	8 + 14	8–10 / 4–5
4 · Oct 5– 11	EGF Fall Cleanup week — sell "what the city won't take"; Herald / KNOX fall-prep pitch; ship /reviews once five exist; hard freeze ~Oct 6 drops the leaves; promo closes Oct 10	6 + 16	12–15 / 5–6
5 · Oct 12–18	Day-30 check: 8 reviews, 11 pages indexed, LSA status; gutter add-on text on every leaf job; landlord-pack pilot with two managers	6 + 18	15–20 / 6–8
6 · Oct 19–25	City vacuum pass 1 (tentative) — schedule by route week; block days at 3+ houses; PTO if backlog over 5 days; helper on leaf days	5 + 20	20–25 / 8–10
7 · Oct 26–Nov 1	Peak continues; copy flips to "the vacuum missed it / gutters now"; junk push in the groups, "before the snow"	5 + 20	20–25 / 8–10
8 · Nov 2–8	Last planned leaf week (median first 1" snow Nov 8); two-visit plan copy into done texts; apartment-association email for a December slot	5 + 20	15–20 / 8–10
9 · Nov 9–15	Overflow leaves weather-permitting, gutters, junk; Ads and Nextdoor off Nov 15; day-60 review Nov 12; 20 reviews, pack positions logged; escrow check	6 + 14	10–12 / 5–6
10 · Nov 16–22	Junk only; plan texts to every fall customer; write CPL by channel	6 + 8	5–7 / 2–3
11 · Nov 23–29	Thanksgiving week; PM turnover calls for December; reply to reviews	3 + 6	3–5 / 2
12 · Nov 30–Dec 6	Apartment-association December meeting; realtor-association decision; landlord packs invoiced net-15	5 + 8	4–6 / 2–3
13 · Dec 7–13	UND semester-end turnover hauls; day-90 close: 28 reviews, 20 plans sold, season CPL into PRICEBOOK.md, clock data replaces the hours in \$8	6 + 10	5–7 / 3–4

APPENDIX A

Model assumptions (scripts/plan-model.mjs)

- Tickets are the midpoints of the pricebook ranges, less 30% of jobs at the 20%-off promo (cap \$75) and 15% of jobs with the \$25 block credit.
- Truck cost = 12 miles a job × the IRS 76¢ rate — that rate is what a pickup mile really costs (fuel, tires, wear, depreciation), and it's also the deduction.
- Dump: landfill \$28 a junk load (the \$23 minimum plus weight), \$12 a leaf load at the yard-waste site, \$9 for gutter muck that rides with another load. Confirm the commercial yard-waste rate at 724 N 47th St on the first drop.
- Card fees: the \$50 deposit is always by card; 60% of balances are by card (Stripe 2.9000000000000004% + 30¢). Cash and check balances cost nothing.
- Helper: \$18/h plus 12% payroll burden, paid for every hour of the job including the drive.
- Tax: 30% of pre-tax profit — self-employment tax plus your federal and ND marginal rates on top of a \$55k W-2, net of the half-SE and QBI deductions. The app's 25%-of-collected set-aside covers it.
- Fall season = 9 weeks (mid-Sept to mid-Nov); spring = 6 weeks. Winter carries the nut with no revenue — that's why the fall number has to be big.

Site hours per job (solo / with helper): small lot 2.0 / 1.25 · standard lot 2.75 / 1.6 · large lot 4.0 / 2.3 · one piece 0.6 / 0.4 · half bed 1.1 / 0.7 · full bed 1.75 / 1.0 · gutters 1.1 / 0.8 · bundle 3.5 / 2.1, plus 0.6–1.0 h of drive and dump per job. All n=0 — triangulated from industry sources, not measured on a Grand Forks lot; wet or matted leaves can double them. The crew clock replaces every one of these after ten jobs.

Five site changes this plan depends on

1. REVIEW_URL → the GBP write-a-review link (20 min, highest leverage).
2. A morning-of text template and a two-visit-plan (spring) template; the review nudge in the follow-up queue moved to next morning.
3. A Minnesota tax line on the estimate, booking page and Stripe balance, keyed off the geocoded state — and no EGF bookings until the MN Tax ID exists.
4. The five service pages and the on-page fixes in \$5; ?s= tags on every outbound link (gbp, fb, ads, call, plan) so the scorecard reads cost per lead from the board.
5. Promo deadline extended to Oct 10; the Sierra's GVWR and the \$1,500-per-quarter payroll trigger recorded in Books and the Crew checklist.

APPENDIX B

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